



A UNIQUE PILGRIMAGE

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By
Kanta-Harvilas (Harishchandra)

Introduction By
Dada Dharmadhikari



Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan
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PUBLISHERS' NOTE

We are glad to publish this account of a unique pilgrimage of four pilgrim sisters, who are on a journey on foot for a period of twelve years. This pilgrimage has been inspired by Vinobaji to revive women's power, to propagate Brahmavidya among women, to develop emotional integration of India, to further World-unity and World-peace and to spread the message of a non-violent revolution in every nook and corner of our country and abroad.

This is the eighth year of this pilgrimage. During this small span of their journey these sisters have traversed more than 16 thousand miles on foot and visited 115 districts of 12 States of India, alongwith a journey of Sri Lanka also.

This account in Hindi was prepared by two selfless workers of Gujarat—Sri Kanta Bahin and Sri Harvilas Bahin known as 'Harishchandra' one compound name given by Acharya Vinoba. It has been rendered into English by Srimati Sarla Bahin, our English sister—Keitherene Hillman, who has taken great pains in making it suitable for English-reading public. We are highly indebted to her for this labour of love. It is also a matter of pleasure that we are publishing this account during International year of Women's emancipation.

We hope that this little book would certainly help in reviving Women's power and furthering the cause of World-peace through non-violent revolution.

INTRODUCTION

The Bhagwad Gita says, "Those whose minds are steadfast in equanimity have certainly attained the fulfilment of life. Attainment of equanimity and unity in human relationships constitute the aim of social life." This sense of unity must be both living and life-giving, it will illumine our every-day contact and behaviour. The Bhoodan Movement was a great stride in the direction of Samya-yoga or the yoga of equanimity. Bhoodan could, perhaps, never become a movement in the sense in which the word is usually understood, since it was not an agitation. Its author was not content with bringing about merely a change in the environment. It sought to bring about a change of heart as well. It was an essay in promoting feelings of mutuality and an active attitude of sharing.

As a matter of course several currents emerge from the mainstream of Bhoodan. Among them 'Mahila Lok Yatra' (Women's pilgrimage to the people) has been a powerful and life-giving current. Such revolutionary activities spring from the innermost elan or intuition of the 'Yuga

Purush' or the 'man of the age'. This is a sure sign of his genius. When the 'Mahila Lok Yatra' was launched with our limited vision we failed to appreciate its immense possibilities. Vinoba's penetrating insight clearly visualized all its potentialities.

The concept of unity of life has its peculiar wisdom, science and art. These three together constitute 'Samya Yoga' (equanimity). To realize that "I am the Brahma"—is not enough. So long as the truth that "all this is Brahma", is not realized, our perception remains incomplete. Only when one realizes that "I am the Brahma" and "All this is Brahma", and "hence I am all this", is equanimity achieved,—if achievement it can be called.

The cosmic form of Divinity is one of the means for the attainment of this realization. The scriptures say that 'God has a thousand forms and a thousand names.' 'Thousand' here denotes not only one thousand, but thousands and thousands i.e. countless. Among these countless names and forms the Universal Spirit (Vishvatma) and the Soul of the people (Lokatma) are the objects of special adoration.

This earth is dear and sacred not only because

it is the treasure-house of unlimited wealth and jewels (Bahuratna Vasundhara); but because it sustains this universe. She breast-feeds all creatures. When this Mother earth evolves into one universal family then alone will it become the real Temple of God and the beloved abode of the spirit of MAN.

That is the main objective which inspires the 'Mahila Lok Yatra'. It is a pilgrimage of quest. These four sisters have embarked on it to discover the soul of the people. In that sense it is a pilgrimage of spirit. They have set about it with 'heart within and God o'er head.' I may seem impertinent, but with the prerogative that age confers, I call these young ladies, my daughters.

"This person in mine, that is another's",—so think the narrow-minded; for those of generous spirit this whole universe is a small family." Every one of these four sisters has discarded the idea of establishing a separate home-stead for herself. They did not choose the traditional role of a housewife. They have set out to realize in their own lives the ideal of a world-family. The whole world is their family, and they are members of this family. For them there is no stranger, no mother's house nor mother-in-law's house,

because they belong no where in particular; they belong everywhere. 'Belonging no-where' and 'belonging every-where' connote two entirely different attitudes of mind. The former stems from narrow self-centredness, from the ego; while the latter has its source in the Brahma. The one is exclusive, while the other is comprehensive. These four sisters have launched this venture to realize this comprehensive consciousness. In this sense their pilgrimage is a global voyage, this globe itself is their Mecca. The real meaning of 'aniket' (having no home) is Vishva-niket (having a home everywhere). One who is 'aniket' is not homeless—a nomad belonging nowhere. One who is 'aniket' is also 'sthiramati' (स्थिर-मति) that is of steady mind. His horizon is boundless. These four sisters have been actuated by this sublime sentiment. This sentiment is also the quintessence of character, the very oxygen of a magnanimous life.

These lady pilgrims look upon India as an epitome and proto-type of the whole world. For them this is not a mere sentiment but an objective reality. Bharat has never had the feeling of a mere territorial or physical nationalism. Mother India has been regarded as a divinity

like our Mother Earth. 'Obeisance to Mother India', is obeisance to the soul of the universe, in other words, to the soul of humanity, to the divinity that dwells in MAN. The realization of oneness with all humanity is a stepping-stone to the realization of the universal form of God. While describing India the great seer Vyas declared, "This land is dear both to Indra, the King of the gods and to Manu, the ancestor of all men". It is dear because it is the shrine dedicated to faith in all life. Indian nationality, therefore, is not circumscribed either by geographical or political boundaries. It springs from a perennial and unqualified faith in 'MAN' with a capital 'M'. That is why India has been our 'holy of holies'. Our devotion to her precludes contempt or disregard for other people. To the sons of mother India, this whole earth is holy Varanasi. Out of this reverence for the mother, the great Shankaracharya established four holy seats of pilgrimage in the four corners of 'Bharat Varsha' (India). It is common knowledge that if there is the sign of recurring decimal on the first and last digit of a mathematical term, the whole term is considered to be a recurring decimal. This means that the whole land of Bharat Varsha is our holy land, and those who live on

that land are our kith and kin. This is the all-consuming passion which has illumined the spirit of these young sisters. Since all Indians are our own, then as a matter of course all men under the sky are our kith and kin. The mantra of 'Jai-Jagat' (victory to the world) is not a mere slogan; it is the expression of this magnificent spirit of the brotherhood of man.

Loyalty to 'Bharat Mata' is, thus, not informed by a spirit of aggressive patriotism but by an abiding faith in the people. To us Man is supreme. The ancestors of the people of India discovered three universal dimensions of social life which hold good for all time. These may very well be regarded as India's distinctive contribution to human culture. These dimensions may be summed up somewhat as follows :—

- (1) This entire creation is the manifestation of Divinity. We are not free to exploit nature and or to plunder it. Nature is a goddess, who enriches our life and makes it more livable. This is 'Vibhuti Yoga'. The attitude of humility which sees divine immanence in all animate and inanimate objects. This is not the primitive cult of the worship of matter or animism.

- (2) To look upon other beings as your other selves. This is known as 'atmaupamya' (आत्मोपम्य) seeing others as one self.
- (3) Reverence for all life, with a capital 'L', and for all Nature with a capital 'N.' Preference for vegetarian food and a positive abhorance for the slaughter of animals are an index of the universal reverence for all life.

These three may be regarded as the most distinguishing attributes of India's cultural heritage. They have not remained only empty concepts. It has been the endeavour of the people of India to realize them in actual human relationships. In this sense 'Brahma culture' may be regarded as universal culture. Perhaps it was this spirit which inspired a poet like Iqbal to sing : अहले बतन का मुझको हर जरी देवता है ! 'Every particle of the dust of this sacred land to me represents divinity.'

Hema Bharali has been a dynamic social worker, more or less a stormy petrel. Dauntless courage and a spirit of adventure, have been her distinctive characteristics. Laxmi Phukan is the very embodiment of geniality. She is seldom ruffled. Nirmal Ved is earnestness personified. Her whole being overflows with noble impulses and Devi is the very picture of placidity. Equipped

with the attributes of courage, geniality, earnestness and placidity this valiant band of four young women has set out on this unique pilgrimage in quest of the soul of humanity. They are trekking this sacred land to seek entrance to the *sanctum sanctorum* of the universal spirit of man. It is not their part to preach or propagate the message of any particular prophet or denomination. They have not been initiated in any particular cult or indoctrinated in any ideology. They are neither 'Bhikshunis' (nuns) nor Sadhvis (women anchorites). They are in quest of the Eternal Man concealed behind barriers of language, culture, costume, cult and creed. Their Sole desire is to seek divinity enshrined in MAN. This universal MAN is above the difference of male and female. Therefore the vision of these young ladies is not clouded by feelings of difference between male and female human identities. These differences have no significance for them. They are not missionaries in any sense of the term. They shun propaganda. In the light of the steady flame of love, which illumines their whole being, they have launched on this pilgrimage in quest of the soul of man. It is not a triumphal march in a bid to establish a particular cult. Love precludes all belligerence. God seems to have blessed them with the divine

gift of spontaneous affection and they are out to share it with all human beings, irrespective of caste, country, culture, creed or sex.

It is generally believed that woman is more suited to the pursuit of this noble cause than man. The development of all human faculties is more essential to the fulfilment of a woman's life as a human being. The cardinal difference between man and other creatures is that Nature has endowed man with no built-in apparatus for self-defence. This limitation is specially conspicuous in woman due to her natural physical handicap. But in spite of this difference between man and other creatures, man is more powerful than all other animals. He seems to be the 'monarch of all he surveys.' This indicates that the source of Man's power is neither in his physical prowess nor in his dexterity in wielding weapons. Therefore the development of man's special powers is more imperative in the life of woman with her physical frailty.

Vinoba's Brahma Vidya Mandir at Paunar is an experiment in the development of man's distinctive power. These four women have crossed the boundaries of the Brahma Vidya Mandir to set out on this pilgrimage. Now the world is

their university for the pursuit of that divine wisdom. Man's liberty depends on relationship, on the cardinal feelings of love and mutuality. Freedom comes out of a sense of fellowship. The freedom that comes as gift from someone else is false and counterfeit. Only that freedom is real and meaningful which springs from mutuality. Love is the breath of such freedom. To an affectionate heart, there is no stranger. The other has become the I, the me. This sense of oneness has no place for fear or apprehension. Love and fear are as antagonistic as light and darkness. These four girls will be the torch-bearers of this magnificent cause for twelve years. The period of twelve years has been traditionally regarded as a 'yuga' (era). Some others call it 'Tapa' (the period of penance). So this penance will continue for a yuga. It is not theirs to enlist support, sympathy or co-operation for a particular programme. They are out on a pilgrimage of friendship. Their watch-word is 'let one candle be lighted by another.' Our good wishes and blessings are with them.

This book has been written by a pair of peerless twins Chandrakanta and Harvilas. They are not natural twin sisters; and yet they may be

called more than real twins. They are not twins by birth but by choice. Their relationship is more intimate and closer because it is voluntary. It would be difficult to find the same degree of mental identification, high-mindedness and unity of purpose even in real twins. This extraordinary identity between these two sisters prompted Vinoba to coin a compound name 'Harish-chandra'. This name is a compound word, though not hyphenated. But their mutual relationship is above all duality. Their united personality is enchanting. Their devotion and faith are contagious.

Their style of writing reflects the beauty of their life. They write out of the fulness of their heart. They usually write in collaboration and mostly in Gujarati. This is perhaps their maiden effort at writing literary Hindi, and this attempt has been eminently successful.

Men and women in general have still to learn that intimate relationship between them need not necessarily be either sexual or biological. Woman is not always the mother, sister, daughter or wife of man. There is also a relationship of love which is above conjugal and blood-relationships. Love and lust almost never go together. Woman

will continue to be man's mother, sister, daughter and wife; but this relationship in love which is above all these relationships is as intimate as it is sacred and sublime. This changes the very texture of human relationships and ushers in a new era of universal culture. Kanta-Harvilas are a symbol of this relationship. The fragrance of their combined personality pervades this book.

I believe the readers will find this book interesting, useful and inspiring.

DADA DHARMADHIKARI

'SOUHAARD'

Wright Town, Jabalpur

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Pilgrim Sisters with Vinoba.

A Women's meeting



1

Walk : Walk : Walk On !

Walk : Walk : Walk On !

‘Charaiveti ! Charaiveti !!’

This injunction of the Vedas has been translated into action in Vinobaji’s life. He walked on, walked on incessantly ! Not for two or four years but for fifteen long years his pilgrimage continued incessantly from Cape Comorin to Kashmir and from Kutch to North Lakhimpur (Assam). During his ‘padyatra’ of forty to forty-five thousand miles he came face to face with Narayana residing in the spirit of the people of India and he fulfilled a unique task of people’s education. This has been the Indian tradition. How many saints, learned and great men have wandered here for the welfare of the people. In this age of science, Vinobaji has once again put into practise this injunction of the Vedas.

He also imparted this ‘mantra’ to our workers : “Walk, walk thou, walk on !” He recalls it again and again :

कलिः शयानो भवति, संजिहानस्तु द्वापरः ।

उत्तिष्ठन् त्रेता भवति, कृतं संपद्यते चरन् ॥

‘Those who sleep, live in the Kali-yuga and their fortune also sleeps. Those who sit, live in the Dwapar-

yuga and their fortune also sits. Those who stand erect, live in the Treta-yuga, their fortune also stands erect, and those who walk, live in the age of activity,—Satya-yuga, and their fortune also walks. Therefore walk : walk thou : walk on !

It is not the times which decide the type of a man's life but man himself creates the age. If we wish to live in the Satya-yuga and to usher it into society, we must keep on walking and educating the people.

Sometimes Vinoba recalls the mendicant Buddha. Lord Buddha said to his disciples:

चरथ भिखवे चारिकं बहुजन हिताय बहुजन सुखाय ।

'Wander about for the welfare and comfort of the many.' The Dharma-chakra will continue to revolve along with the Charana-chakra. Sometimes he recalls the signs of a devotee laid down in the Bhagawad-gita : अनिकेतः स्थिरमतिः that is, 'his wisdom is steadfast but his feet continually move on.' Walk, therefore, walk, walk on !

A call to Women's Power

Thus one day Vinobaji discussed the idea of a twelve-year women's pilgrimage and the pilgrimage began. Inspired by him, four women have set out on a continuous walking pilgrimage for twelve years. Vinobaji wishes Stri-shakti to come forward for the service of India and to act as a catalyst to inspire and awaken the people. He has called it 'Lok-yatra' and has given the words of Madhavadeo of Assam as a mantra : लोकर हितक चिन्ति नित, that is, continually meditate upon the welfare of the people. Service of the self will also be effected by this, but the aim of serving the public will predominate.

Combined with continual concern for the public weal education must be carried on in a spirit of affection. Vinobaji says, "Words of women are always sweet. When mothers talk about their genuine welfare the people understand them. Males have to remain out-side the house, whereas sisters can go right upto the hearth."

The pilgrimage has to continue for twelve long years. Not for one or two, but for twelve long years. That too not by rail or car, but on foot. Moreover, this is not a question of wandering in mountains and caves for individual sadhana; but living in society and wandering among people. Every day a new halt, a new place, a new village, a new house. New people every day. For them every village is a place of pilgrimage and its inhabitants are the Lord to be worshipped. At day-break they have to set out for the next village. Their feet know no halt, in cold, heat or rain. Charaiveti ! charaiveti!!—walk, walk thou, walk on ! Day-by-day a continual pilgrimage for twelve years. Lord Rama was banished to the forest for fourteen years, but this banishment is among the people for twelve years. They certainly have to leave their home and wander, not in the forest but living among the people. That is why it is Lok-yatra, a pilgrimage among people.

A pilgrimage of joy

So these four women are continuing their pilgrimage. Thus they are achieving a happy vision of India and of the human heart. Sometimes they travel along a national high-way, at others on a narrow foot-path. Sometimes they walk through hill paths three to four

thousand feet high, sometimes through the plains. For them every pebble on the way is Shiva incarnate. Sometimes their halt is in a great wealthy city like Bombay, while at others it is in some remote and dusty village. Sometimes they are accommodated in a Dak-bungalow with every comfort, at others in a doorless small cottage, where there is hardly room for them to spread their beds. Sometimes as many as ten to fifteen people join the pilgrimage while at others it is difficult to find even a guide. So far as food is concerned, sometimes there is a great variety, while at others they have to remain content with half a meal or even with water. But the sisters find great joy in all this since they have themselves chosen this life of *banishment among people* to carry a great message from a great man. Therefore this Lok-yatra or pilgrimage among people, is a march full of joy. They have to keep walking with joy at meeting and communing with people, with a longing in their heart for their good and well-being.

●

2

A Twelve-year Programme

The seeds of the idea of a pilgrimage to the people can be seen in Vinobaji's pilgrimage in Assam. Vinobaji was on pilgrimage in Assam in the year 1961-62. He wandered there for about a year and a half. He saw that Stri Shakti is well organized in Assam and that it holds a special place in the sphere of social service. As a matter of fact in many States of our country the condition of women is very backward and pitiable. But in States such as Kerala, Gujarat, Maharashtra and Assam women are advanced. In Assam in particular women are leading in the sphere of social service. Sushri Amalprabha Baudeo has been working there for a number of years and she has been able to gather together a band of devoted women-workers. Moreover, she commands great respect and esteem in the public.

Organized Stri-Shakti in Assam

Thus during his pilgrimage in Assam, Vinobaji became well acquainted with organized Stri-Shakti. Since then he had been telling women-workers there that the light of Stri-Shakti which is shining in Assam should

come forward to serve India. It would indeed be a great thing if a band of women came forward for an All India pilgrimage.

Vinobaji often says that Brahma-vidya is well developed in India, but India's women have contributed very little to it. As a result, whatever Brahma-vidya has developed here is one-sided. It has not been able to achieve perfection. Woman became a target, an objective. On the one hand worldly people regarded her as a means of satisfying desire, our entire literature and art revolves around woman, while on the other hand recluses and mendicants made woman the target of renunciation. They propagated hatred and contempt for woman to such an extent that they were prohibited from looking at her or talking with her. They even called her the gateway to hell.

There is a famous story of Mirābai. She once went to Mathura. A Vaishnava Sadhu was living there. When Mirābai went to meet him, he refused to see her. She was told that Swamiji did not look at a woman's face. She said in a touching and sarcastic way :

मैं तो जाण्युं तु के ब्रजमाँ परमपुरुष छे एक,
ब्रजमाँ बसी तमे पुरुष रखा छो, भलो रें तमारो विवेक!

'I understood that Lord Srikrishna is the only Man in the whole land of Braj, and all others are merely his Gopis. I am surprised that you have remained a man even while living in Braj. This is a strange discrimination.'

Thus woman has been made a target from both sides—on one side of attachment, on the other of renunciation.

This happened because Brahmagvidya has been reserved as the province of men. Therefore it has remained one-sided. Now women also must come forward in the sphere of Brahmagvidya. Vinobaji has continuously stressed this point. He has even said, "In my younger days I trained some young men. Now in my last years, let me serve womenfolk. I wish to spend the rest of my life for the emancipation of women." What intense feelings Vinobaji has for women! That is why he continually appealed to sisters from Assam to come out of Assam and wander through the whole country.

Vinobaji also felt that Assam has produced great men like Madhavadeo and Shankerdeo—who are known throughout Assam, even to the children. Yet we find that outside Assam very few people know the names of these two great men, because Assam is in a corner of the country. It has little contact with other states of the country. Therefore, if sisters of Assam set out for a tour of the country, they would take with them the Assamese culture and India would come to understand it.

Vinobaji also says that we cannot understand the value of our own store-house until we move out. There is an English proverb which says:—'A prophet is not honoured in his own country'. Travelling develops one's brilliance and gives an opportunity to broaden his vision. Thus Vinobaji talked to sisters from Assam and persuaded them to undertake a tour of the country.

Inspiration for a Tour of India

In September 1967, Vinobaji was staying at Pusa Road in the district of Darbhanga, Bihar, when some

lady-workers from Assam came with Sushri Amalprabha Das to meet him. On this occasion, Vinobaji again placed before them the idea of an All India Pilgrimage and threw more light upon it. Sushri Hemprabha Bharali was with them. She is a prominent lady-worker of Assam. Vinobaji had been thinking of her in particular for the All India pilgrimage. Now when Vinobaji repeated his suggestion of an All India Pilgrimage, Hem Bahin expressed her willingness to cast off all her responsibilities in Assam, and take up this work. Vinobaji suggested the name of Lakshmi Bahin of Maitri Ashram as the second member of this pilgrim-party. It was decided that these two lady-workers from Assam should participate in the All India Pilgrimage.

Sushri Nirmal Bahin of the Shanti-Sena-Vidyalaya, Indore was also present there while the pilgrimage was being discussed. She had come to visit Gramdan Villages in Darbhanga District after the Ziladan. She was so attracted by the idea of the pilgrimage that she immediately expressed her desire to join it. Vinobaji said : एकस्तपो द्विरभ्यासी त्रिप्रवासी—'Penance alone, two for study, three for travel' and thus included Nirmal Bahin in the party. It was decided that the party should set out on this pilgrimage at an early date.

By degrees details of the pilgrimage were discussed. What should be the name of this pilgrimage? Many suggestions were made. When the name 'Lok-yatra' was suggested Vinobaji repeated the melodious couplet of the Namaghosha :

लोकर हितक चिन्ति नित ।

That is, 'Good men always think of the well-being of the people'. This couplet of Madhavadeo truly expresses the objective of the pilgrimage. Thus the name लोक यात्रा—(Lok-yatra) was accepted. This name indicates the inspiration as well as the scope and functions of the pilgrimage.

A Twelve-year Programme

How long should the pilgrimage last ? Vinobaji said that the idea of a twelve-year Bharat-yatra is part of Indian tradition. For the sake of experience, we should begin with a three-month pilgrimage and then meet for discussion. We should exchange conclusions, evaluations, observations & experiences and then chalk out the future programme.

Whence should the pilgrimage set out ? Vinobaji suggested that the pilgrimage should begin from Kasturbagram in Indore. This was also appropriate since Indore is the sacred land of Ahilya Bai, who in the true sense was the mother of her people and it is also the headquarters of the work of our Rashtramata Kasturba. Moreover, in 1960 Vinobaji stayed in Indore for five weeks and was in close touch with the womenfolk there. Therefore from all points of view it was appropriate that this unique pilgrimage should start from Kasturbagram, Indore.

The Form of the Pilgrimage

What should be the form of the pilgrimage ? Vinobaji said that it should be entirely cultural and spiritual. It was not necessary to think much more in advance about the form. No blue-print was necessary even

for the daily routine. The programme should be adjusted on experience, in accordance with the needs of the pilgrimage. Learning from experience, the shape of the pilgrimage would gradually emerge. Propaganda through literature would be a part and parcel of the pilgrimage. Our institutions at state and at local level or our friends and sympathizers would make all arrangements for the pilgrimage.

After this discussion, the women-workers set out on the pilgrimage. Vinobaji recited another couplet from Sri Madhavadeo : 'भारत रत्नद्वीप, मनुष्य शरीर नौका, रामनाम महारत्न सार' i.e. 'India is an island of jewels, the human body is a boat and the name of Rama is the essence of this great Jewel.' Let these sisters enter India, the island of jewels, and choose the great jewel the name of Rama. And with the words शुभास्ते पन्थानः i.e. 'blessed be thy path'—Vinobaji bade them farewell.

The Auspicious Beginning

From Pusa Road, these three sisters went to Indore, whence the pilgrimage set out on 25 th. October, 1967. In the year 1960 Vinobaji had given his talks on the brown hillock at Kasturbagram combined with his exposition of the seven forms of 'Stri-Shakti' such as Kirti, Shri, Vani, Smriti, Medha, Dhriti and Kshama as given in the Bhagvad-gita. He had invoked Stri-Shakti. The yatra started from this same place in the early dawn. How many loving hands applied the tilak to the foreheads of pilgrims ! Sweets were offered and good wishes expressed. Lakshmi Bahin says that many such emotions as enthusiasm, fear and affection swept through her mind and automatically, Gurudev, Rabindranath's devotional

line : “आमादेर यात्रा हलो सुरू एखन ओ गो कर्णधार तोमारे करि नमस्कार.....” (With salutations to Thee Lord! our journey hereby starts) came to her mind.

Their feet moved on. Everyday, a new village, a new house and new people. Sometimes some local people also joined the pilgrimage for one or two days. Sushri Devi Bahin was one of these. She was a teacher in the Kasturbagram Rural Institute. She joined the pilgrimage for some days. She was impressed by the idea of the pilgrimage and decided to leave her work and become a pilgrim. This is a definite example which proves that one lamp lights the next, that light springs from light. Thus the party now had not three, but four members.

Assessment after Three Months

The pilgrimage continued in the district of Indore from 15 th. October, 1967 to 25 th. January 1968. As previously decided the sisters then went to meet Vinobaji to assess their experiences of three months and make future plans. At that time he was staying at Rajgriha. All friends joined to review the experiences of the three months, which were most encouraging. They must certainly complete twelve years. In the light of experience gained in three months the details for the pilgrimage were worked out afresh. Prior preparations, daily routine, financial arrangements, private study, sale of literature were all discussed. Vinobaji's guidance was of course available. Vinobaji once more clarified the special aims of the padayatra. They were : awakening **Stri-Shakti**, arousing a consciousness of Indian

unity, propagation of Brahmavidya and spreading the message of revolution. Combined with daily thought on the welfare of the people, these particular subjects should be highlighted. They must arouse the expression of Satya, Prem, Karuna in society.

Vinobaji's advice to pilgrims

People, who undertake a long pilgrimage, must maintain a healthy body and a healthy mind. Vinobaji gave the pilgrim sisters some advice on the basis of his own personal experience. Such as :

Do not fall ill. It requires sound full sleep and clear bowels. In case of constipation, you should take issafgol. You should take as much milk as possible and take less solid. You should drink boiled water, and remain always happy and cheerful. You should enlarge upon one another's good points, however insignificant they may be. You should study both individually and jointly. You should be happy in your wandering life and should never grow lazy or indifferent. Such a pilgrimage naturally encourages both mental control & mental development. It is not becoming to grow bitter in the course of a day's contact, therefore control yourselves for a day. It is not very difficult to maintain self-control for a day. Moreover, this helps the development of the mind, since the inspiration of the pilgrimage is the welfare of all. कडक वचन मत बोल—'No harsh words must ever pass your lips.'

There is a prayer in the Vedas 'O Lord, give me the sweetness of speech and let each day be a good day for me.' So, you will always use only sweet words. There is another mantra in the Vedas which says : 'From birth, I am a fire. There is butter in my eyes.'

It means that you are filled with compassion, purity and love and nectar in the mouth. As mothers, your words should always be sweet.

Taking this advice to heart, our four sisters set out on the pilgrimage with Vinobaji's blessings. The pilgrimage started again in the district of Sarguja in Madhya Pradesh, on 26th. February, 1968. Now the pilgrimage must continue. Twelve years must be spent in constant wandering. This pilgrimage is continuing ceaselessly, from one state to another. More than five years have passed. The pilgrimage still continues and will continue for seven years more. लोकेर हितक चिन्ति नित; चरैवेति, चरैवेति—The march must continue with the daily thought of the well-being of the people. Walk, walk thou, Walk on !

3

Four Pilgrim Sisters

Lakshmi: the Joyous

This incident happened about twentyfive years ago.



A girl fourteen or fifteen years old was telling her mother that she would not marry but would serve the country. She looked like a doll and hence she was called Putul (Dolly). Her mother replied : "Hush. What kind of service will you do? You have read up to the sixth class only. Had you been Jawahar Lal's Indira, the case

would be different. She has travelled at home and abroad and has gained much experience. Whom will you

serve? Don't talk such non-sense. Be busy with your household work." But Putul had made up her mind. She must serve the country and work for others. What did it matter if she was not highly educated? God would provide her the wisdom necessary for service.

The Desire to Learn

Putul had a strong desire to acquire more knowledge and to improve her education. But what could she do? She was only a girl. Her mother was not in favour of more education. Putul also had to suffer many more discriminations and observe all sorts of rules and regulations. Little Putul was very unhappy, and she sometimes wished to revolt.

Since she had a strong desire to acquire more knowledge, she always used to read books. Once she read how Turkish women had achieved freedom from the burqah. Many determinations, alternatives and ideas surged through Putul's mind. She read some stories about people who had left their homes for the sake of education and completed their education by doing odd jobs. Putul began to think of doing likewise.

At last, in 1947 she left home. She enquired about the work done by the Kasturba Trust. She was already seeking such an opportunity. She felt that there she might have an opportunity of learning how to serve. Therefore she took admission to the training centre of the Trust. Thus at the age of sixteen Putul left home in the name of Kasturba and took training for service of the people.

This Putul is none other than our pilgrim Lakshmi Fookan. Even now, at the age of fortytwo, Lakshmi somewhat resembles little Putul. With a fair complexion, snub nose like a Chinese girl, thick hair and short stature, you will always find Lakshmi smiling.

Serving the Villagers

After two years of training, Lakshmi went to serve villagers as a worker of the Kasturba Trust. The work also developed her personality. Yet she sometimes felt that over-emphasis on action may be detrimental to learning. So, she tried to fulfil her thirst for knowledge also. She went to Sevagram for a year. There she had the opportunity of living with our larger family from all parts of the country. She never missed any opportunity of gaining knowledge and experience. In 1957 she joined in a study of the 'Gita Pravachan' in a camp under the guidance of Vimala Thakkar. Lakshmi says, "This study increased my interest in the Gita."

Now it was necessary to achieve further development. On the one hand, Lakshmi felt that working with an institution and with the help of money from a central fund prevents identification with the people. On the other hand, she also felt a thirst for knowledge. She was ready to remain immersed in action, but action can be transformed into in-action only when combined with knowledge and devotion.

In close contact with Vinoba

Lakshmi's both wishes were fulfilled during Vinobaji's Assam tour. He toured Assam for eighteen months. Lakshmi had joined Vinobaji's party on the pretext of selling

literature. This opportunity was the starting point for a new phase in Lakshmi's life. During the course of the yatra, Vinobaji taught Marathi to a few Assamese girls. Lakshmi would sit listening to him. She was so anxious to learn, that even in this way she picked up quite a lot. Gradually she too was accepted as Vinobaji's student. He tested her metal. He made her learn his 'Gitai.' That was his way of teaching her Marathi. She also began interpreting Vinobaji's talks into Assamese.

Finally when he was leaving Assam, Vinobaji sent Lakshmi to the Maitri Ashram, which he established in 1962. It is situated in the District of North Lakhimpur (Assam), quite near the international boundary. Lakshmi lived there for five years as a responsible Ashramite. She left the Ashram on Vinobaji's suggestion for a twelve-year pilgrimage among the people. She suddenly received Vinobaji's order, and winding up her work there, within ten days she came away. She had no time even to see her mother. She left for a pilgrimage of twelve years without even saying good-bye to her mother.

Continuity and Dedication

An incident during the Gujarat pilgrimage, comes to our mind. The pilgrims were at Bharuch. Lakshmi received a letter. She read it. It was time for the meeting, so she had to go at once. Lakshmi spoke in the meeting. After the meeting she said, "I have just received news that my cousin and a dear friend of mine have both been killed in an accident. We were very close to, one another". Lakshmi would not like us to describe this as

non-attachment. This balance, this dedication, this missionary zeal are Lakshmi's nature. The word 'non-attachment' would weigh heavily upon her. She once said, "I do not know how and when I became dedicated after coming into contact with Vinobaji. A saint is greater than our parents."

Her continuity is also unique. Vinobaji told her to write him a letter daily. And the subject? Anything. Just a daily account of what she had seen, heard, done, read, said or thought. This has continued since 1963. It has been continuing without intermission. However busy she may be, however tired she may be, she may be unwell, yet Lakshmi cannot rest without writing a letter to Vinobaji. This has become a part of her nature. If we expressed surprise at this continuity Lakshmi would say, "Oh! What can I do? I can't live without writing a letter to Baba". Vinobaji always asks workers to write to him. Lakshmi's is perhaps a unique example among two or three thousand families of workers in this country.

Happy with everyone

Idleness is anathema to Lakshmi. You will always find her doing something or other. She is fond of embroidery and sewing. Even today the desire to learn something new is as keen as ever. She is anxious to learn the language and read about the saints of the area where these sisters travel. This helps in bringing her into close contact with the people. This is why, although Lakshmi is educated only up to class six (from the official point of view!) she knows six languages. On their entry into Gujarat, she brought her speech written in Gujarati.

She speaks and writes Marathi well. She has translated Vinobaji's 'Jnandeo Chintanika' from Marathi into Assamese.

There is an old story. Lakshmi must have been about seventeen or eighteen at that time. She was working in the villages. One night a thief broke in. She was alone in the house, but still she was not frightened. She began beating a thali (metal plate) loudly. The villagers ran up and the thief took to his heels. Lakshmi says, "Afterwards I wept a lot, but I was not afraid. Since then I have the firm faith that God is always there to help us." Contact with Vinobaji has helped to strengthen her self-confidence and faith in God.

You always find Lakshmi joyful and happy. She is always smiling. This is her life motto. Once she said, "Baba has given me a challenge, whether in joy or in sorrow, I must always laugh and never cry." Many people have called her the "Laughing Sister." Her pilgrimage continues with joy and laughter.

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Nirmal : the Emotional

"Inquilab Zindabad ! Inquilab Zindabad ! Inquilab Zindabad !"

A procession was passing through the city of Lahore. Bhagat Singh had been hanged. A wave of revolt was surging through the people. It seemed as if the whole city was out on the streets. There was no end to the crowds

on the roadside. A mother was standing on the side of the road with her little daughter. We do not know how much the child understood. But seeing the procession, she also waved her hands and shouted loudly. She was not even old enough to talk clearly, let alone to understand the slogan of 'Inquilab', but that little heart must have been impressed.



After a few years that little child began to go to school. Those were the days of the national movement. The echoes of the struggle for freedom resounded everywhere. Sometimes a national leader would come, sometimes a national festival would be celebrated and some times there was a strike in the school. Thus Munni

('Nirmal's childhood nickname) grew in the national traditions. There was a good group of girls. Their little hearts surged with varying desires. They dreamt of many ideals, viz. "We also will serve the nation. We also will sacrifice our lives for the freedom of our country."

A query to Nehru

One day Pandit Jawahar Lal Nehru came to Lahore. Those were the days when people enthusiastically sang—

भारत का डङ्गा आलम में बजवा दिया वीर जवाहर ने ॥

‘Brave Jawahar has sounded the bugle of Indian freedom throughout the world.’ An immense crowd surged to see and hear Jawahar Lal. Our Munni was also there. Yes, but now we can no longer call her Munni, as she was now an adolescent. She began to think, “Why not ask Jawahar Lal the way of service? I’ll surely ask him.” As soon as Nehru completed his speech and came out of the meeting hall, our adolescent Munni approached him. She greeted him and said, “I want to ask you a question.”

“Do ask,” Jawahar Lal said affectionately.

“I want to serve the country. What should I do?”

Affectionately clasping her face in both hands, Jawahar Lalji said, “My dear child, when you grow up you will understand everything.”

Frontier Gandhi Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan was standing beside him. He gave his motto to our adolescent—
“Wear khadi and make others wear it.”

Some years later our adolescent, now a college girl, went to Delhi to take part in a conference, as a member of the Lahore delegation of the Students’ Federation. The conference was on an All India basis. Delegates had come from all parts of the country. Here Nirmal had a glimpse of the wider family of the country she wished to serve.

This Munni, this adolescent, this college girl, was none other than Nirmal Bahin Ved of our pilgrim party. She was born in a respected Punjabi family of Lahore. As her mother could not acquire much education, so she wished to educate all her children well. Nirmal received her early education in Lahore. After the partition of the country her family had to leave Lahore and they came to Delhi. In Delhi the family had to face severe financial difficulties. Therefore she had to combine tuitions and employment with education. She had to cycle about twenty miles a day. She also spent some time working in refugee camps.

Gandhiji's idea of 'simple living and high thinking' touched Nirmal to the core. She never looked at riches and jewellery. Gandhiji's precept of the 'dignity of manual labour' appealed to her. She became convinced that no work is high and no work is low. It is wrong to feel ashamed to carry a headload. In cities like Lahore and Delhi Nirmal would carry a tin of wheat on her head to the grinding mill. Thus she became used to doing any manual work unhesitatingly.

'I will Not Marry'

As Nirmal grew, her parents, as is usual with parents, began to worry about her marriage. Although she had unequivocally said that she did not want to marry, her parents paid little heed to what she said. Moreover, they thought that even after marriage one may serve the country. But Nirmal was resolute that she would not indulge in worldly botherations.

One day Nirmal's parents talked seriously about the

arrangement of her marriage. They were reckoning how many clothes to buy, how much gold to give, what ornaments to order. Nirmal was shocked to hear all this talk. She burst into tears and asked her parents why they did not believe her. Once again she said emphatically, "I shall never marry. Never ! Never ! Never !" She wept and sobbed. This touched her mother and she said, "Marriage is a happy event in life, but if you do not wish to marry, rest assured that we shall never try to force it upon you."

The family needed help for the education of her younger brother and sister. Nirmal worked to fulfil her duty towards the family. When she felt that the family could manage without her, she left home and went straight to Indore. She worked there for several years as director of the training centre for social workers. Later she worked in the Shanti Sena Vidyalyaya and took part in the Gramdan Toofan campaign. At first the idea of Gramdan seemed to her to be quite utopian. But from work in the field she realized the real value of Gramdan and Gramswarajya. She did some hard thinking. There were still four years to the Gandhi Centenary. She decided to work for Sarvodaya at least until the Gandhi Centenary.

A Turning Point in Life

Nirmal began to walk through the Tribal areas of the district of Sarguja in Madhya Pradesh. This was a turning point in her life. She came very close to the poor Adivasis. People addressed her affectionately as 'Bahinji'. The people loved and respected her. Nirmal

says that she had a new birth among those adivasis. A new awakening came into her life.

In 1967 she was on a visit to the Gramdan areas in Bihar. Nirmal happened to be present on the day when Vinobaji talked to the sisters from Assam. She was so much attracted by the idea of a pilgrimage to the people that with Vinobaji's permission she decided to join the pilgrimage.

In her enthusiastic and poetic speech Nirmal Bahin is now carrying the message of Sarvodaya and Brahmanism from village to village. She speaks with enthusiasm, courage, revolutionary fervour and clear ideology. This touches people's heart and mind. Among intellectuals she puts her ideas logically. Ramcharitmanas—Tulsi Ramayan is her favourite book. She enchants the whole audience with her devotional and emotional recitation of the couplets of Ramcharitmanas. Her sweet voice moves the heart.

Nirmal has some of the peculiarities of the Punjabi nature. A buoyant and cheerful temperament, figurative elaboration of speech, the habit of embracing friends and massaging their limbs and head. She is also not apt to worry.

Search Fulfilled

Due to this freedom from care, she is not bothered by the trials of the pilgrimage. She enjoys its pleasures freely. She once said, "The pilgrimage helps to cleanse the mind and eliminate the ego."

From childhood she had a desire to take part in Gandhiji's work. Now she finds the vision of Gandhiji in

Vinoba. Therefore the way has opened. In her sweet voice, she frequently sings in meetings :

जिन खोजा तिन पाइयाँ, गहरे पानी पैठ ।

हौ बौरी डूँढ़न गयी, रही किनारे बैठ ॥

‘By diving into deep water, one who seeks will find. I sat like a fool on the bank for fear of sinking.’ She herself has dived into deep water. Continuing her pilgrimage, she exhorts others also to leave the bank.

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Devi : Balanced and Simple

That brown mound at Kasturbagram, Indore. With the blessings and good wishes of all, a party of three pilgrim sisters was setting out on a pilgrimage which was to last twelve years. All hearts were moved at this great and brilliant idea. There was a teacher of the Kasturbagram Rural Institute among those assembled that day to bid farewell to this group, who on the inspiration of a great man was setting out on a pilgrimage to the people of India.

These brahmacharini sisters were setting out on foot for twelve long years, without a single pie in their pockets, relying on the people and on God as their only mainstay, with the aim not merely of personal salvation, but the welfare of the people. They were setting out to wander among the people, continually concerned with their welfare, with a vision of the myriad forms of God and of man.

An Insinuation

Devi thought deeply : "Is this not exactly what I have been seeking for years? I have been waiting with faith in my heart that God would show me the right path. So, in keeping me here on this unique occasion, is not God giving me an insinuation?"



In this state of mind, Devi could not take leave of the pilgrims. Her steps kept step with their steps. She could still not come to any decision. Yet, she might remain with the pilgrims for a few days and enjoy the practical experience. She saw things for herself. This increased her attraction which continued to grow.

Finally a letter was written to seek Vinobaji's permission. In a few days his blessings were received, and this teacher of the Rural Institute resigned from her job and undertook the loving service of humanity at large.

This teacher was none else than Devi Rijwani, the third member of the pilgrimage party. She was born

in Sindh, but received her education and culture in Indore. Although her mother had died during her childhood, her aunts brought her up with affectionate care. She was deeply influenced by her uncle's life of renunciation and discipline. She received a high education and passed her M.A. in Sociology. Apart from Sindhi, she also has a good command over Hindi and Urdu.

How to achieve satisfaction ?

Sindhi families are usually fond of food and dress, but Devi was never much interested in these. She was inclined to be introspective. She saw the dissatisfaction in the lives of well-qualified people. She wondered how one may achieve satisfaction in life, and arrived at the answer, "in spirituality". She began to understand that the inner self is entirely different from outward riches. Therefore she decided that she would not become entangled in worldly affairs.

Then the search began. First she read a great deal of spiritual literature. She studied the writings of Sadhu Vaswani, Guru Nanak, Ramakrishna Paramhansa, Vivekananda, Vinoba and others. She also met some mendicants and saints. She visited many ashramas, but she was not satisfied. Then she read most of the Sarvodaya literature. Although the ideology appealed to her, she did not feel inclined to join the movement. We might say that at that time Devi was more inclined to 'nivratti' than to 'pravratti.' She was much impressed by the following saying of Sri Ramakrishna Paramahansa: 'A passenger alighted from the train. First of all he arranged his accommodation and then with his mind

at ease he set out to see the town. So man should first reach his destination before taking up any service.' Devi was much influenced by this saying. At Kasturbagram she had a strong inclination to consecrate her life to village-service. But a doubt still lurked in her mind that all this would be possible only after self-realization. She waited with the abiding faith that God would show her the path.

This is the Path !

And truly, God did show that path. Devi felt an inner inspiration when she heard of the idea of the pilgrimage to the people. In this she saw an unusual combination of efforts for self-realization combined with identification with the people. Today she has identified herself with the pilgrimage. She is the youngest member of the party. She expresses her ideas in a style all her own presenting them with logical arguments. Her speeches are free from incoherent ideas, they are well organized. She makes her points one after another in a systematic way.

She has become a great adept in the art of making others her own. She mixes with all in a natural way. Sindhis are of course good salesmen, and so is Devi Bahin. Efficiently and earnestly she enlists subscribers to the Hindi monthly 'Maitri' and she always discusses literature as an inherent part of the pilgrimage. Immediately on reaching the day's halt, she seeks out people to help her in this work. Many helpers are soon attracted by her enthusiasm. Then she spares no effort in this hard work.

Devi has a simple and sensitive heart. She cannot bear to see anyone in trouble. But during the pilgrimage in the Gujarat she herself had to suffer severe physical pain. In Kutch, one day during the early morning walk she was bitten by a snake. The venom spread throughout her body and she began bleeding from the mouth. Devi bore all this pain patiently and silently. She had to rest for several weeks.

Lessons from the Pilgrimage

Devi has her own independent tendencies, yet she says, "I have learnt much from the pilgrimage. We must renounce our personal insistence, otherwise we cannot live a community life."

She has full faith in this pilgrimage. She feels free of care. She says that since the aim is decided, all other worldly considerations are secondary and devoid of meaning. Brahmacharya has become natural for her. All desires have automatically come to an end.

Once during a walk with Vinobaji, he took her hand in his and said jokingly, "You will never desert this hand, will you?" Devi says that when she has found both her natural path and a 'guru' like Vinobaji, there is no question of deserting him. She holds the hand not of a person, but of an ideology. The pilgrimage will not end only in twelve years but would continue for her whole life. She says, "On the one hand, I cannot bear to see the dependence of the people, they have to become self-reliant, and on the other hand they shower so much love upon us that I cannot rest lest I should be accused of ingratitude. Both these considerations always inspire me to keep on." And so her pilgrimage continues.

Courageous Hem

People did not like this at all. It seemed strange



that so much care and affection should be showered upon a girl. Admitted that there was no shortage of means, but after all, she was only a girl. She would, in the end have to go to someone else's home. It would, be entirely different if she were a boy. It is not proper to shower so much love on a girl ! But her par-

ents had given her freedom even to move about freely in public. She even enjoyed riding a horse or an elephant and driving a car. Had she any sense of propriety at all ? It all seemed very strange.

Everything so strange

Some more years rolled on. The girl was now grown-up. She had become a social worker. But she was still as unusual as ever ! Even now, some things still seemed strange. People could not understand why she refused a party ticket for elections. How many people crave to

become an election candidate ! How they rush about for it ! But when she is pressed to take a party ticket, she blankly refuses. Admitted that she wants to serve, but what does that matter ? Is not the legislature the means to highest service ? She might even become a minister or so. But she refuses and says, "Power politics is wrong in itself. We have to arouse the power of the people. I cannot understand all this." All this strikes people as being very strange.

Time and tide wait for none. Now she is about fifty. People are still amazed of her curious ways. For example, during her childhood she never worked in the home. There were plenty of cooks and other servants. But today, at this age, she wants to do all her work herself. She has always travelled in first class, or by car. But today she is out on foot for a pilgrimage. She has to walk and walk. Can we blame people ? Why should it not strike them as strange ?

Distributing her Treasure

Do you know who this strange person is ? This is Hem Bahin Bharali, the leader of the women's pilgrimage, which has set out to realize a strange idea of Vinobaji. 'Hem' means gold, and 'Bharali' means store. A store of gold ? No, a store of what may be called golden thoughts and experiences. Under the inspiration of Vinobaji she has set out to distribute this treasure throughout India.

North Lakhimpur District is in the North Eastern corner of the country. Hem was born there in a village. She spent her childhood in a city and was also educated

in a city. She is the youngest of her parents' five children. Therefore she received the greatest affection. The eldest daughter died soon after her marriage, so her mother decided that Hem should not marry. Then why should she not treat this daughter like a son ?

A Provincial Social Worker

From the very beginning, Hem grew up in the atmosphere of the national movement. One of her brothers was jailed. Her father conscientiously fulfilled all his social obligations, large or small. Hem developed an affectionate friendship with Amalaprabha Baudeo, and joined her in social work. She graduated from the University of Gauhati. She also came in contact with Gandhiji. She lived at Sevagram Ashram in 1946-47.

Later she worked under the Kasturba Trust in Assam for three or four years. She is now a senior worker of the Trust and responsible for the social work of whole Assam. While doing her Trust job she took up various other kinds of constructive work also. She has worked with the Khadi Board, the Social Welfare Board, the Citizen's Council and Bhoodan Gramdan. She has travelled throughout India and Assam. There can hardly be anyone in the public field in Assam who does not know Hem.

She has been in touch with members of political parties, government officials and village head-men. If there is any work to be done in the secretariat, one immediately remembers Hem. Then the work is easily put through, as Hem is able to make people understand her and get her work done.

‘Yes Baba, I am Ready’

When Vinobaji was in Assam in the year 1961-62, the whole responsibility for the organization of his pada-yatra fell upon Hem Bahin. Ever since then, Vinobaji had been pressing her that her work should not be confined to Assam, but she should travel throughout the whole country. However, she was not prepared to abandon her many responsibilities. Even at Pusa Road, in 1967, when Vinobaji again stressed an All India Programme, Amalaprabha Das and other friends wished to appoint Hem as Member-Secretary of the Bhoodan Board. However, Vinobaji continued to lay stress on the pilgrimage. One day he asked her “Hem, are you ready?” Hem did not need to consult anyone. The inner voice prompted her and she replied, “Yes Baba, I am ready !”

She made up her mind and the pilgrimage began. But her body was not so prepared. She suffers from a gastric ulcer. Moreover, she is not much used to a hard life, and therefore, even today her body sometimes calls a halt. Then at times she has to take leave from the pilgrimage and rest. But as soon as she is better, she is off again on the pilgrimage. Hem feels that this pilgrimage though inspired by Vinobaji is really inspired by God.

The image of Vinobaji as a revolutionary has sunk deep into Hem’s mind. She firmly believes that Vinobaji is furthering Gandhiji’s cause and that his contribution to Satyagraha, Trusteeship and Lokniti is unique. She regards ‘Gramdan’ as the highest conception of the day. Hem’s own village was the first registered and Gazetted Gramdan of Assam.

Social work and maintenance

Hem's father was in favour of social work, but he was of the opinion that social workers should take nothing from society. They should not become a financial burden on society. At first, Hem accepted this advice, but now she says that this is a wrong attitude, it is a form of egoism and contains the hidden sentiment of ownership. If we have consecrated our life to society, we should accept our maintenance from the public. Hem feels that the Gramdan-programme has brought her to this realization.

From her own experience Hem frequently asks younger-workers like us to take care of our health. She says that since our body is a means of service, we must take care of it properly. If in our enthusiasm for social service we are careless and inattentive about proper sleep, food and rest we shall regret for it later on and we shall not be able to do our work properly. This is a form of betrayal of service.

During the Gujarat pilgrimage, Hem fell ill. The doctors suspected cancer and advised an immediate test. Yet Hem remained perfectly calm. Her self-confidence was unshaken. Later she was admitted to the Ahmedabad Cancer Hospital for a complete check-up. The report was negative. We were all relieved.

Affection and Rebuke, both

Hem is very particular about punctuality. Any default upsets her. Her language is straight-forward, some times even blunt. She does not care for formality or soft words. She does not hesitate to say anything unpleasant.

Thus she may appear to be some-what dry. But just as a hard coconut contains sweet water and creamy flesh, so all who come into close contact with Hem cannot fail to be touched by her inner sweetness. She loves you, but also chides you when necessary.

It is a part and parcel of her love that she will do her utmost for you. It is her nature to look after everyone with motherly love. She is always considerate about the welfare of workers and comrades.

Her specialities include a long experience of social work, quick assaying of people and a psychological approach. These characteristics are very helpful in the pilgrimage. She has abiding faith in the pilgrimage. She often says that her previous work was 'rajsik' while the present work is 'satvik'. Here there is ample scope for high thinking, contemplation and inner development. Vinobaji has told her, "There are two sides to service. First, external activity, which should be the basis for explaining our ideas to society. We should take up some solid programme and then present the idea in order to explain it. The second side is the service of our inner self. We think and contemplate and then present the results to the public. Work is then planned on this basis. So far you have been engaged in practical work, whereas the ideological basis was secondary. Now you have to work in the opposite way. The ideology will now be primary, practical work secondary." Hem's new pilgrimage is continuing thus with Vinobaji's inspiration.

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These are our four pilgrims. They have joined hands for a pilgrimage through the land of India. For twelve

years they will wander in every corner of the country. Their greatest mainstay is the inspiration of such a great man as Vinobaji. Mutually learning and teaching, they have to walk on परस्परं बोधयन्तः—‘They will be mutually complementary.’ Lakshmi’s calm, gentle and happy voice, Nirmal’s emotional, enthusiastic but poetic voice, Devi’s simple, balanced and logical talk, and Hem’s clear and courageous expression, based on experience, all these are really complementary and enrich the pilgrimage.

All the four are Brahmacharinis. Since childhood not one of them has wished to set up house. Now, with the inspiration of a great man, they have such a means for realizing individual and community welfare that brahmacharya has become all the more natural. Worshipping that Brahma, that Supreme Reality, they are walking and walking on. The Bhagwat says :

यमास्थाय नरो राजन्, न प्रमाथेत कश्चित् ।

धावन्निमील्य वा नेत्रे न स्वलेन पतेदिह ॥

‘If a man lives with faith in these teachings, he will never be guilty of ‘pramad’, he will not be guilty of committing omissions, errors or sins. Therefore, even if he follows it blindly or precipitately he cannot fall.’

They have such a beautiful and simple path that they can follow it with joy. Charaiveti ! Charaiveti !—‘Walk ! Walk thou ! Walk on !’

The Five Main Aims

From the beginning, Vinobaji wished that this pilgrimage should assume a purely cultural and spiritual shape. The aim before us is Satya, Prem and Karuna. The ideas of love, restraint, purity and peace should be propagated in society. The pilgrim sisters must move on daily with concern for the people's welfare. There are five main aims of this pilgrimage :

1. THE REVIVAL OF WOMEN'S POWER

One of the main aims of this pilgrimage is the revival of women's power. Today our Prime Minister is a woman and from the beginning women have been given equal franchise here. In England and many other European countries women had to struggle hard to achieve the franchise, but from the very foundation of our democracy we adopted universal franchise. This does us credit. Yet in India today, women's power is on the whole inert and the position of women in some parts of the country is so pitiable that we feel ashamed at the thought of it.

The purdah System

The purdah system has as it were made our women lifelong prisoners. The system is most prevalent in Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh, since the influence of the Muslim rulers was stronger here than elsewhere. The people of these States had to imitate the customs of their rulers. There was also an element of fear. This weakness of imitating the rulers has always been a feature here. Muslim women observe purdah. In these States all women had to imitate them.

We frequently have to go to villages in Bihar. We cannot bear to see the plight of the women there. We once visited a family in which a new daughter-in-law had just arrived. She sat with her veil drawn down to her breast. We said, "Please let us see the bride's face." But how could that be? To begin with, the new daughter-in-law cannot unveil her face before anyone. We insisted and finally raised her veil. But what did we see? The bride sat with her eyes closed. We persuaded her again and again to open her eyes, but she did not budge. We spoke to her mother-in-law, her sister-in-law, but they replied that this was the local custom that a new daughter-in-law must not open her eyes before anyone. There was no man present there—we all were women. And yet the daughter-in-law did not open her eyes. This was the case not only in one house, but in five or six. We came to know that this custom prevails in many villages of Bihar. The new daughter-in-law has to live in one room for a year or two. She must not come out of it. This might as well be called a gaol.

Thus hundreds of thousands of women-folk are bound in the chains of slavery. They are kept within the four walls of the house. Vinobaji frequently says with pained sarcasm, that the village women of Bihar have put even Yogi Arovindo in the shade. Shri Arovindo undertook 'sadhana' by confining himself to one room. But he also sometimes came out to appear before people. But in Bihar, a woman enters the house after marriage never to come out again. She is not even allowed to see the sun. When once she has entered the house, she will remain inside it until her dead body is carried out.

Many Forms of Bondage

Today, women are in the grip of many forms of bondage and injustice. These bondages start even from the cradle. The birth of a son is celebrated, sweets are distributed, everyone is happy whereas everyone is disappointed at the birth of a daughter, and even the mother is unhappy. Later on, there is much difference in the education of a boy and a girl. The mother always reminds a girl that being a girl she will have to go to someone else's home. There is discrimination in everything—in food, in education, in work. If a boy wishes to do some work, the mother stops him and says: 'Why do you leave your books to do this work?' Whereas if the poor girl sits down with her books even after completing all her household chores, her mother will ask what is the use of all this study. After all, in the end she will have to work in the kitchen.

This is the condition in many of our homes today. The condition of many women in the rural areas is still pitiful. Evil customs such as dowry prevail. These

customs predominate in the cities too. In so-called progressive society the form of dowry may have changed, but even today there are many castes and sub-castes in which the marriage of a daughter costs twenty to twentyfive thousand rupees. Women's attachment to ornaments is well-known. That too is one reason for their slavery.

The Slavery of the Golden Cage

Slavery does not come only in the form of iron chains, sometimes it comes in the form of a golden cage too. It is more difficult to escape from this type of slavery since at first we do not realize it. Until we do realize it we cannot feel the pinch. Instead, the starling inside the golden cage swings away happily. Today, so-called educated and cultured women are in this condition. In the educational field they are in no way behind man nor are they backward.

They are working in offices on a par with men. But have they yet escaped from their real slavery? Or are they in deeper water than before? Look at their way of living, their clothes, their artificial decoration. They wish to display every portion of their body as if they were just decorative dolls, or toys to be played with. Woman's real slavery is betrayed by the distorted form in which she is depicted in films, advertisements, newspapers and periodicals. How can she be considered free until she escapes from this? How can she be regarded as the equal of man? How can she fulfil her appropriate role in the organization of society?

The Organization of Society

Today, this is a great challenge before women-folk.

Men have been organizing and administering society for centuries. In all walks of life the responsibility for organization is in their hands. And what do we see today? On all sides there is conflict, exploitation, war and party-politics. Now our mothers must come forward. Just as we need both a man and a woman to run a family, so both are equally needed to organize society. If society is to be saved, the power of motherhood, of love, must become active, or else the world will destroy itself as Bhasamasur reduced himself to ashes by putting his hand upon his own head. Therefore, the need of the age is that men and women should be regarded with equal social esteem. Women must come forward, and women must jointly organize and administer society. To achieve this, women will have to take the lead. The virtues of sacrifice, restraint, love, compassion and gentleness are in their very nature. The development of a non-violent society calls for these virtues. First of all, our women must realize the basic strength residing in these qualities. So far great men such as Mahavir Swami, Dayananda Saraswati, Maharshi Karve, Gandhi, Vinoba and others have striven indefatigably for the emancipation of women, but until women themselves come forward to free themselves from physical and mental slavery and realizing their true strength become active in the social field, they cannot rise.

The pilgrim sisters place these revolutionary ideas before society. The awakening of women's-power is one of the main aims of the pilgrimage.

2. TO ACHIEVE BRAHMAVIDYA

Vinobaji stresses upon this point that women's-power

cannot be awakened until we strive for the attainment of Brahma-vidya. He hopes that some Shankaracharya may be born among women today. The emancipation of women is possible only if a woman emerges who is as profound in wisdom and asceticism as Shankara was. A woman should become a teacher of Brahma-vidya. There have been many women devotees, but so far, no teacher. Therefore brahma-vidya has remained one-sided in India. It is one thing to be a devotee and another thing to roar like a lioness with one's own convictions. The heart of a devotee overflows with emotions, but this must be linked with revolutionary zeal. Yes, a Mira or a Lalla may come to revolt against society and earn for herself a place in the spiritual field. Mira was also a poetess and therefore she was able to influence the public. Otherwise devotees usually prefer solitude and are indifferent to society at large.

Devotion and Revolution

Many Jain women become nuns. Some women undertake continuous pilgrimage. Many men became disciples of Mahavir, but they were more concerned with the emancipation of the self than with that of the people. Vinobaji wishes that women, who are mindful of the public welfare as well as their own, should influence society and initiate social change. They must be like the sun, which sheds its light fearlessly. It will never think, "There is a cave. It is dark there. How can I enter it?" Can darkness survive the light of the sun? So, women must develop the capacity to face social opposition and to throw off social darkness.

However, this power cannot be awakened without the effort to achieve brahmavidya. Our country has produced some learned women devoted to the cause of Brahmagvidya, but more particularly since the Buddhist period women have on the whole lost their place in the social and spiritual fields. Ordinary women have been confined within the four walls of their home. The public feels that a woman must marry, that she cannot live alone and also that she cannot observe brahmacharya. This is still the public opinion today.

Revolt against Society

If any girl expresses her will that she won't marry, her mother will scold her saying, "Is that possible? An old man may die unmarried, but has there ever been an old woman who died unmarried?" This is why a girl is brought up to look upon marriage and a good husband as the aim of her life. When a girl has passed the normal age of marriage, her parents cannot sleep peacefully, and everyone begins to worry about her marriage.

We have to revolt against this state of affairs. Our four pilgrims have taken vow to live and die unmarried. They wish to propagate the idea that any girl can live as a 'brahmacharini'. Like men, we also have the right to a spiritual life.

Vinobaji founded the Brahmagvidya Mandir at Pavnar, Wardha. Brahmacharini sisters live there and are undertaking Samouhik Sadhana. This pilgrimage is in a way as it were a mobile Brahmagvidya Mandir. The party is carrying the message of Brahmagvidya to the people by means of this pilgrimage throughout the

country. Thus we shall succeed in our aim when there is a combination of the mobile element with the Brahman-vidya Mandir.

The Basis of Equality

Today brahman-vidya has to be applied in daily life. It can provide guidance even with regard to people's daily problems. We have to eliminate all differences of caste, untouchability and sex, all social distinctions between employer and employed. One supreme soul pervades all and its light must spread abroad. Man now wishes that society should recognize him as a man, and that all differences should be eradicated. In this world, air, water and light are free to all. Night comes to all, the dawn comes to all. It is not a case of night for some and day for others. Creation has achieved equality everywhere. Interdependence is also the law of creation. Our present age calls for such cooperation between man and man. Efforts are being made to bring about equality in external matters. Yet true equality cannot be achieved until a change is brought about in man's inner tendencies. Brahman-vidya alone may become the basis of such equality.

Thus the second main aim of the pilgrimage is to carry the message of Brahman-vidya throughout India, in the hope that it may be adapted to the daily life of the people.

3. EMOTIONAL INTEGRATION

The third aim of this pilgrimage is the emotional integration of the country. The distance between Kashmir

and Kanya Kumari or between Dwarika and North Lakhimpur is not less than two thousand miles. Most of our States are bigger than many countries of the world. Whereas Europe is divided into many countries, in a subcontinent like our country, we have allowed many diversities to flourish. And what a variety ! Variety in language, in dialect, in religion, in sect, in caste, in class, in food and drink, in modes of living, in dress and customs, and yet for centuries we have been bound together with one thread. The feeling of cultural and spiritual unity has always pervaded the Indian subcontinent. Our ancestors taught us that all these differences are only outward. The heart of mankind is one, the outward differences are secondary. The more liberal we are regarding these outward differences, the greater the happiness we shall enjoy. Unity in diversity has been our true glory. When flowers of different colours bloom in one garden, they add to the beauty of the garden.

Our Unique Tradition

This glory of ours has grown through the messages carried by rishis and munis, saints and pilgrim monks. They helped to maintain the unity of our great and varied country. From the very beginning they inculcated a broad outlook in the minds of the people and founded tradition which could strengthen the cultural unity of the country. Great religious merit has been attached to the pilgrimage to our sacred places. Adi Shankara laid down the tradition that the priest in the Kedarnath Temple in the Himalayas should be Nambu-

dripad Brahmin from Kerala in the south. This tradition still continues unbroken. How far-sighted these traditions were !

At that time there were neither jet planes nor aeroplanes, nor trains nor cars. Yet people carried water from the sea at Rameshwaram in the far south, to Kashi in the north and performed abhishek of the Lord Vishwanath with that water. Similarly, people setting out from the north with Gangajal reached the south and performed abhishek of Rameshwaram with that water. These ascetics also imparted knowledge. How many saints and wise men, including even Muslim saints were always walking through the country. Shankaracharya from Kerala travelled around India and established four spiritual centres, in the four corners of the country. He was born in Kerala and he died in the Himalayas. His samadhi can still be seen at Kedarnath. Saint Namdeo of Maharashtra reached the Punjab and died there. His religious teachings have been incorporated in the Guru Granth Sahab. It is a matter of great honour that the teachings of a person from another State are incorporated in the local teachings. Guru Govind Singh was born in Patna (Bihar). He travelled on foot as far as the Punjab, and later died in Maharashtra. Saint Appa Swami of the Shaiva sect of Tamil Nadu lived in Bihar for twelve years. There he became a Jain, studied the Jain religion and subsequently returned to Tamil Nadu. From Assam in the eastern extremity of the country, Shankardeo and Madhavadeo reached Dwarika in the west. Tulsi Das, Kabir, Gautama Buddha, Mahavir, Nanak, Surdas, Mira, all travelled on foot throughout the country and

all of them strengthened the cultural and spiritual unity of the country. Even when the kings went on war, the emotional unity of their subjects remained intact.

Mutual Contact : A necessity

Today, this tradition of the saints is decaying, and consequently the emotional unity of the country has become a problem. Today the means of transport have increased tremendously. Previously there was less political unity than there is today. Now we have one federal government for the whole of India, but we see differences arising. Differences of language, religion, state, and boundaries have arisen. Disputes about state boundaries and the distribution of river waters have been continuing for years. A few years back relations between the North and South were so much strained over the question of the national language that there was a danger of civil strife. At that time only the fast of a great man like Vinobaji saved the situation.

Therefore, the maintenance of an atmosphere which may help to sustain the emotional integration of the country is essential. Contact between people of different States must increase. We must appreciate the culture of different States. In spite of the progress of science, today such contact and mutual understanding has decreased. Vinobaji frequently complains that the names of Shankaradeo and Madhavadeo which are famous in every household of Assam are unknown to the people of other States. Then how can emotional integration be achieved?

The specialities of all States must be propagated throughout the country. If people would come and go through different States and become acquainted with

one another, this would be very helpful for national integration. Today this is a paramount necessity. Should only all-India leaders or political leaders tour the country? This would not help national integration, since "party"-leaders come in contact with only a "part" of the people and not with the masses. Moreover, the age of leadership is now passing away. Therefore, a band of "Servants of India" must now flourish. Our ordinary workers must go and work in one another's States at the grass-root level.

Unity in Diversity

Thus the achievement of emotional integration in the country is one of the main aims of the pilgrimage. Sisters from three different States have set out to walk through the country for twelve years. Wherever they go, they try to achieve integration with the culture of the area. They also study the scriptures and literature of the saints of that region. It has become an integral part of the pilgrimage to study and memorize books such as the Namagosha of Madhavadeo in Assam, the Ramacharitmanas of Tulsi Das in Northern India, the Jnaneshwari of Maharashtra, and the Tirukkural of Tamil Nadu. This must be done not from the old, or communal, but from the modern and spiritual point of view. Vinobaji has suggested that these sisters may speak in meetings in their mother tongue, which may then be translated into the regional language. People should have an opportunity of listening to the sweet tones of the languages of other States. This will be a happy experience. The people will then begin to understand the fundamental unity of India.

4. WORLD-UNITY AND WORLD-PEACE

There is one more Indian tradition. In India we have never harboured narrow or parochial sentiments. From the beginning we have held a comprehensive view of the world and of the human race. Who are we? The Vedas declared "Humanity, Vishwa Manushya"—the universal man. Jnaneshwar Maharaj also said that the world was his home. Madhavadeo said that he had been born in the world. He did not say that he was born in Assam. Narsinha Mehta also similarly sang, "I was born on the earth, in India." The concept that the whole world is one has been prevalent right from the time of the Vedas.

The Whole World a Family

We are living in the days of radio astronomy. Scientists tell us that there is not only one, but crores of worlds and innumerable suns. So vast is the expanse. This is why our seers said, "The whole world is like a small family." Here also they did not use the word—"family", but "small family." They regarded the whole world as a small family. The larger family is the whole universe.

Today science has made the whole world one. With the aid of science, the human voice can travel from one end of the earth to the other in a few seconds. When the world has grown so small, should we continue to waste our time over these trivial differences? Science has considerably widened our minds. Yet still the heart of man is shrunken. If we are to benefit from science, we need an extremely broad mind combined with an extremely large heart, or else we shall be defeated.

Synthesis of Science and Spirituality

In this context, Vinobaji has spoken of the synthesis of science and spirituality. Science can provide only the speed. Unless this speed is given a proper direction, science can annihilate mankind. Atomic power can bring heaven on earth or hell on earth. Today it is essential for man to divert this power towards construction rather than destruction. The synthesis of science and spirituality is essential to achieve this and whereas science will provide the speed, spirituality will provide the necessary guide-lines. Hope for the future of the world lies in the synthesis of these two factors.

From the beginning, Indian culture has been inclusive. Moreover, there has also been a deep spiritual effort here. So, India has a special contribution to make in giving science a correct direction. This is a challenge before our newly independent India.

This synthesis has to be achieved between all the peoples of the world. We must endeavour to help men to become one by transcending national boundaries and making international wars a thing of the past. From the beginning our national movement was permeated with this feeling. We have never conceived a narrow parochial nationalism. We have always believed that our nationalism can never be antagonistic to other nations or to humanity. Ravindranath Tagore sang,

हे मीर चित्त पुण्यतीर्थें जागो रे धीरे ।

एइ भारतेर महामानवेर सागर तीरे ॥

‘Oh mind, awake slowly on the sacred shore of our India, the ocean of universal man.’ Vinobaji also has given the motto—‘Jai Jagat.’

So, another important aim of the pilgrimage is to prepare the public-mind for all these factors of world-unity and world-peace.

5. MESSAGE OF A NON-VIOLENT REVOLUTION

To achieve world-peace it is imperative to raise the concept of the family to that of the village, and the concept of the nation to that of the world. Today this idea must spread through society. Without this, permanent peace and prosperity in society is impossible. This is the main aim of the 'Gram Swarajya'-movement. Gramdan and Jai Jagat are mutually complementary. The whole village must become a family and the village must become a model of the whole world.

The village as a Family

If the village becomes a family, it means that the village council should accept the responsibility for the welfare of all the residents of the village. The villagers should share both their joys and their sorrows. Gandhiji placed before us the ideal of a Sarvodaya social order. Vinobaji has given momentum to this ideal. At least the basic necessities of life should be available to all and Gram Swarajya should be established in every village. We shall achieve true democracy only when the villagers conduct their own affairs. Today the affairs of the country and of the world are in the hands of a handful of people and they have made the world unbalanced. To escape from this, we have to move towards a decentralized economic order, a decentralized social order and a decentralized political order. All this has to be built up by the power of the people.

This pilgrimage will also contribute to this revolutionary work of gramdan and gram-swarajya. These pilgrim sisters, with concern for the welfare of the people, will explain all these points of social change. They will carry the message of revolution to the people. This also constitutes one of the main aims of the pilgrimage. Thus this pilgrimage includes a motherly and affectionate form of social education. Vinobaji has said that woman's voice is always sweet. When mothers come out into the world and explain their children's true welfare, the children readily grasp it. Of course, the welfare of the people is also achieved when men move about. But when women are on the move they can reach the inner rooms, whereas men have to remain in the courtyard. Women can reach direct to the hearth.

Thus the five main aims of this twelve-year pilgrimage, are the awakening of women's power, the effort to achieve Brahmaildy, the emotional integration of the country, world-unity and world-peace and the message of a non-violent revolution. These are the main aims before the pilgrims. Although the actual form of the pilgrimage is spiritual and cultural, the pilgrims have always the thought of the people's welfare. As a result, people's education will be achieved naturally. The main thing is the continual realization of God. The pilgrims always try to feel that the entire creation is permeated with God, and that they are walking for the realization of God. With this feeling and with concern for the welfare of the people, they walk on. Their motto is charaiveti ! charaiveti !!—Walk ! Walk thou ! Walk on !

5

A Day With The Pilgrims

The sun has not yet risen. It is still dark. Stars are twinkling in the sky. Perfect peace pervades creation. A party is moving forward, breaking this peace with their light footsteps. A man with a lantern in hand leads the party. Some eight, ten or fifteen people follow him. Some study the sky, some listen to nature's silent harmony, some are deep in meditation, some are engrossed in deep thought, some silently repeat the name of God, while others softly chant Vedic hymns, whereas some are just walking naturally without any particular thought. Their feet move on, they cover the distance, the last halt recedes, the new day's halt draws near.

The Distance Decreases

Gradually, the dawn breaks. Nature's movements begin, and the pilgrims also brighten up. Sometimes a question is raised, sometimes a point about the previous halt arises, whereas sometimes arrangements for the coming halt are discussed. Sometimes people join the pilgrims to discuss some particular subject, or to ask advice about their personal affairs and so they talk with the pilgrim sisters. Sometimes if a Sarvodaya worker or

leader happens to come, there is some talk or discussion. While walking, there is joy in silent thought and contemplation as well as in discussion.

Community Meditation in the way

Slowly the dawn grows brighter. At the hour of sunrise the sisters seek for a suitable quiet spot. It may be a field, or a clean space beneath a tree, where they all sit down. First there is ten minutes' silence. During the silence some meditate, some remember their family deity, some fall into contemplation, some meditate on the formless, while others are lost in various thoughts. Subsequently they take up community study. One sister reads from a book, while the others listen. If anyone asks a question, there may be a joint discussion. After spending about half an hour in this way, the pilgrims move on. Now the new halt draws near. Usually they reach the halt between half past seven and eight o'clock.

Maintaining the Programme

Daily they must move on in this way from one halt to the next. The distance to be covered may be any thing between six and ten miles. According to this distance, they will leave the previous day's halt between four and five o'clock. Sometimes the road is difficult and lonely. Then the villagers remark : 'Why this hurry ? There may be thieves or robbers on the way. Wait for daylight. We will start a little later.' But the pilgrim sisters answer, "Dear friends ! We have to start as decided. We must reach the next halt in time. And what is there to fear ? If our heart is free from fear, then there is no out-ward fear. What will robbers seize from us ? They

also are our own. Therefore let us take the name of God and set out." They set out.

The alarm clock rings an hour before it is time to start and they all get up. Finishing their ablutions and packing their luggage, they all prepare to start. A fifteen-minute joint prayer is held before starting. Immediately after the prayer they all set out. Though the halt was only for a day, many friends have been made in the village. With their affectionate behaviour and talk the pilgrim sisters have captured many hearts. So at the time of farewell, many eyes are wet. Some friends walk a short distance with them, some go as far as the next halt, whereas some wish to enjoy their company on the way for a few days. Sometimes the halt may be at such a village where for some reason or another people are less interested in the pilgrimage. It may be difficult to find even a guide there. But such villages are rare, one or two in hundreds.

An affectionate welcome

When the pilgrims reach the next halt between half past seven and eight o'clock, they receive an affectionate welcome. The local organizers have informed the villagers in advance. At some places they receive a grand welcome. The whole village turns out to see and listen to these four pilgrims who are walking throughout the country. The elders, the women and the children all gather for the welcome. Sometimes people come beating drums, singing songs and shouting slogans. In different States there are different customs of welcome. Some where women come with vessels on their heads and with the shripal. They apply the red tilak and the rice to

their foreheads, and garland the pilgrims with flowers or hanks of yarn. Adivasi women come with pitchers smeared with ccw-dung in which they have grown barley seedlings.

The pilgrims are led in a procession to the meeting place, and the villagers welcome them. Sometimes school children present programme. The sisters explain in brief and simple language the aims of their pilgrimage.

Later, when they reach their lodge for the day, after bath and breakfast there is time for personal contact. There is crowd around this house all day. The children wander around these strange visitors and listen to them and watch them with curiosity. Exactly at half past ten the pilgrims repeat the Vishnu Sahastra Nam. This daily recitation is followed by joint study. At this time they study books about saints of the region they are crossing.

Continual Public Contact

After this the pilgrims take their meals, rest and study. From three o'clock until seven o'clock there is one programme after another. At every halt there is a separate women's meeting, which is well attended. The pilgrims explain to them the plight of women and how to awaken womens' power and abolish the discrimination between the sexes, how to educate their children and how to carry on devotion to God. Women are very much interested in such discussions. Once the veil of formality is raised, women freely discuss their affairs with these sisters. They place their problems and difficulties before them and they receive guidance and solace from the sisters.

A public meeting is also arranged. Village meetings are usually held at night. But since our pilgrims have to set out early the next morning, they must retire early. Vinobaji has insisted that during the pilgrimage they must take care of their health. They should get sufficient sleep. The meeting is held in the evening. In this meeting the idea behind the pilgrimage is explained in detail. Speeches are followed by questions. Later there may be joint discussion and individual exchange of views.

Apart from villages their route also covers towns and cities. At such places the halt may last anything up to a fortnight. They spent as many as forty days in Bombay. Here also they move on daily to a fresh halt. Every day they stay in a fresh neighbourhood. Separate meetings are arranged for people of different professions : teachers, students, labourers, lawyers, government servants, police, prisoners, doctors, merchants, constructive workers, political workers and so on. In Bombay the pilgrim sisters also went to meet prostitutes.

After the evening meal at seven o' clock, prayers are held at exactly eight o' clock. After prayers they observe complete silence. No talk, only self-study, contemplation, writing and sleep. The same routine again from the next morning.

Sarvodaya Literature

The pilgrims keep with them some Sarvodaya literature. The sale of this literature continues almost the whole day, but especially at the meeting. Some books are specially advertized in the meeting. After the

meeting the sisters enrol subscribers for Bhoodan and Sarvodaya periodicals and appeal to people to read them. Thus, even after the day's halt is over there is scope for the idea to grow.

Books and bedding are sent by a conveyance. Usually they use a bullock cart for transport from one village to the next. Sometimes they may also use a jeep. All this is arranged by the villagers, by local friends or by Sarvodaya workers.

Reliance on Public Support

From the financial point of view this pilgrimage depends entirely on the public, not on any institution or individual. The public undertakes the full expenditure of the pilgrims. They are generously entertained and the villagers gladly contribute any little overhead expenditure.

The following incident occurred in a poor village. After completing the day's programme, the sisters were preparing to rest. Just then two village women arrived and after some talk suddenly asked, "How do you meet your expenses?"

"The village people do the needful."

"Good. Then please tell us how much you have received in our village today?"

"Nothing at all. But there was really no need. Money comes from somewhere or other. We never have any difficulty in that respect."

The women went away, but they came back after half an hour and putting five rupees into the hands of the sisters said, "This is from us. We must maintain the good

name of our village." The sisters tried hard to dissuade them, but they would not heed. They left the money with them. Thus people affectionately meet the sundry expenses of the pilgrimage. Usually they receive more than their actual needs. Why should they allow it to accumulate? As they complete the pilgrimage of a district or a State, they donate the balance, which remains after meeting all the expenses of the pilgrimage, for Sarvodaya work in that district or State. Why do they need to accumulate money? For, every place is their home. Every home is their bank. They can open the door whenever they wish.

One Day's Rest in Ten

Following Vinobaji's advice, the pilgrim sisters observe one more rule. After about every ten days, they have one day's rest. There will be no public programme on that day, no meeting, speeches or discussions. They rest for the whole day or do their own work as they choose. This is very necessary in a twelve-year pilgrimage.

This is the daily routine of the pilgrims. Almost every day the same routine. But each day a new place, a new halt, a new village, a new lodge and new people. For them every village is a place of pilgrimage and the villagers are their Lord for worship. Before the sun rises they have to leave for the next village and have to keep on walking. Charaiveti ! Charaiveti !!—Walk ! Walk thou ! Walk on !

Across the Boundaries of the States

Charaiveti ! Charaiveti !!

'Walk ! Walk thou ! Walk on !' They have to walk, to keep on walking. This is why every day there is a change of village, after a few days a change of district, and after a few months a change of State. As a matter of fact, for pilgrims such frontiers have no meaning. In the dark of the early morning when the day's walk begins milestones and frontier boundaries cannot be seen. For the pilgrims there is always the same earth, the same sky, the same people everywhere. There is also the same human heart, the same affection, the same good wishes, the same faith and devotion. For them every village, every State, all people are their own.

Yet, for the sake of administration, State boundaries do exist. So, during the pilgrimage, they come to the point where the boundary of one State finishes and the boundary of other State begins. Here the people of one State bid farewell to the pilgrim sisters with wet eyes, while people of the other State welcome them affectionately. This happens continually. Every State has its own specialities. Language, dress, customs and habits

may be different, but everywhere the human heart is one. Thus, with the happy glimpse of unity in diversity, the pilgrims move on.

The start: Madhya Pradesh

Our pilgrim sisters started from Madhya Pradesh. On 25th. October 1967 as the dawn streaked the east, the pilgrimage began from Kasturbagram. Many a hand affectionately applied the tilak to their foreheads and offered sweets. For three months they travelled in the city and district of Indore. Then the sisters stayed with Vinobaji for guidance, for about six weeks. They again set out on foot on 26th. February in the Sarguja District of Madhya Pradesh.

Sarguja is a tribal area, where terrible poverty abounds. The pilgrim sisters met many families who boil maize flour in water and drink it as their daily food. This drink is called *paiz*. Here this is the staple food of the poor. The poor chop wood from the forest to sell in the town. Even a small boy will carry over a hundredweight of wood.

Their houses are built of mud, but they are neat and clean, and artistically decorated. While plastering the mud walls with black, red and white clay they decorate them with designs. Although these people are poor from the economic point of view, they are rich in heart. They are simple. Those who live in close contact with nature of course are natural and have a simple nature.

Rajmohani Devi has done wonderful work among the Adivasi people of Sarguja. This happened in the year 1951. The district of Sarguja was in the grip of a

severe famine. One day this woman was sitting on the bank of a river, hungry, tired and depressed. A saint came and said to her, "You tribal people are dirty, you drink, you eat meat and that is why you are dying of hunger. Go and tell the people that if they give up these bad habits, everything would be well." Since that day this uneducated, illiterate tribal woman left her husband and children to become a mendicant. She began to wander from village to village talking to people about social reform and devotion to God. Thousands of people joined her movement. They gave up drink and meat. They began to wear home-spun and hand-woven khadi. They keep their homes clean and tidy. Rajmohani Devi says that this work is Gandhi's work.

Rajmohani Devi gave the pilgrim sisters her blessings. She also stayed with them for some days during their pilgrimage there. They met her devotees, both men and women at every halt. Rajmohani Devi considered the work of the pilgrimage as her own work. One day she said to the pilgrim sisters, "Today, women are afraid of their husbands. They are suffering from the bonds of illusion. Man will have to listen to those who have borne them. They cannot ignore their mothers. It is good that our sisters have come forward to awaken people."

In Braj : The Land of Lord Krishna

The pilgrimage continued in other districts of Madhya Pradesh until August 1968, and then they passed through Uttar Pradesh for a month or two. The pilgrim sisters, especially those from Assam, were anxious to see Mathura, Vrindavan, and other places in the

land of Braj. Hundreds of years ago Shankardeo and Madhavadeo, the great saints of Assam, came as pilgrims to the land of Braj. In their writings they refer to the land of Braj and to the play of Lord Krishna. Hem Bahin and Lakshmi Bahin were very anxious to see this land of the Lord Krishna Kanhaiya's play.

At first, the Pandas of Mathura did not spare even these sisters. But when they came to understand that these sisters have set out on foot for a twelve-year pilgrimage of India, their whole attitude changed. Then, instead of asking, they began to offer ! They would say, "Please have some milk. Have some refreshment !"

The villages of Uttar Pradesh are neither very big, nor very small. The sisters noticed some advertisements in bold letters on the walls of houses in towns and villages as well. They asked why people allowed the walls of their houses to be disfigured in this way with red and black. They were told that the advertisers pay for this.

In the land of Guru Nanak

On 20th. October 1968 the people of Haryana welcomed our pilgrims in their State. The pilgrimage continued for about a year in this State, which is the birth-place of Guru Nanak. The pilgrims went from Haryana to Himachal Pradesh and the Punjab. One day there was a meeting in a 'gurudwara'. The Guru Granth Saheb was placed on a pedestal. The pilgrim sisters gave their talks. After the meeting, people said, "You are doing our own work. Guru Nank told us to repeat the name of God, perform good deeds and eat only after feeding others. You teach the same thing."

In Haryana they visited the historical place of Kurukshetra and Panipat and also the Pattikalyana Ashram, the centre of constructive work, where they stayed for a day. Here they saw cows which give as much as fifteen to twenty litres of milk. On one hand, prosperous villages glowing with electric light, with pumping sets and with maunds of grain on the threshing floors demonstrated the green revolution, and on the other hand they demonstrated the equally glaring social disparity.

On the hills of Himachal

After Haryana the pilgrims visited Himachal Pradesh. They had to learn the art of climbing up and down the hills. Sometimes a steep one thousand foot climb while at others a steep one thousand foot descent. Deep valleys below them, high hills towering above them. The hills at hand looked green, while the further hills blue. Sometimes there was snow on the hilltops. The sky and the snow seemed to meet.

Here there are a few big villages. On the hill-tops or the slopes, eight or ten houses compose a village. Within the villages the houses are far apart. The fields on the hill terraces look very beautiful. Life in the hills presents many problems which cannot be faced alone. Therefore mutual cooperation becomes essential. To survive on the hills, they have a continual struggle with nature. Their faces reflect courage. On the whole the economic condition is poor and their diet is unbalanced. Yet the general health of the people is not bad. Poor and rich alike have rosy cheeks. The reason is, pure air, natural surroundings, boundless sky and a free life.

Here our pilgrims found more of sheep breeding than of dairying. One family may have as many as three or four hundred sheep and goats. This is their main source of livelihood. They look after their sheep as if they were their children. Almost everyone spins wool and pasham and this is woven into cloth by weavers.

In Prosperous Punjab

Then came the Punjab. Our pilgrim sisters always remember an incident which happened here. It had been raining heavily since midnight. The rain was continuing even at four o'clock. The sky was heavily overcast. It was pitch dark. The sisters began their walk on the mud bank of a canal. In spite of their rain-coats they were drenched to the skin. At every step there was the danger of slipping on the sticky mud. On reaching their destination they came to know that their luggage could not be brought that day. The villagers gave the sisters some bed-sheets to wear. They took off their wet clothes and wrapped themselves in these. Their appearance was completely changed. One looked like a Burmese, another like a Naga and another like a Khasi of Assam. Their luggage did not arrive at all. They had to remain like this all day.

There was a stay of seven days in Chandigarh. Every day programmes were fixed in different places. Although the population of Chandigarh is very small, the city is widely spread out. Every sector of the city has a school, a college, a hospital, a market, a flour mill. Therefore naturally people of one sector have very little contact with those of another.

An Old Woman's Foreign Trip

In the Punjab, the sisters found that even in villages the paths are paved. There has been a great deal of development. People are hardworking and enterprising. From every village some people have gone abroad, some to Africa, some to England or America. In one village they heard that twentyfive per cent of the villagers were abroad. The sisters asked one old woman, "How did you like it abroad? Would you like to go again?" The old woman replied, "I lived there with my son for eighteen months. I liked it very much. Foreigners work honestly, they are honest in their dealings and they are very clean." This answer raised a question in the mind of our pilgrims : "India is said to be the land of spirituality, then why is this feature of the West not found here?" We all have to seek the answer to this question.

At Amritsar a friend put Rs. 500 into the hands of Hem Bahin and said : "When Vinobaji came here, I did not have any land, but I very much wished to give him something. I made a silent resolve, but I doubted whether he would accept money or not. Now, ten years later you have come. Yesterday I heard your speech and thought that the time had now come to fulfil my resolve." How deep and long abiding is the impact of ideas and resolves.

The Sarvodaya Conference

In October 1965 the Sarvodaya Conference was held at Rajgriha, in Bihar. Vinobaji was attending the Conference. He suggested that the pilgrim sisters should also attend the Conference. Thus they would have a chance

to meet friends working in the Sarvodaya movement. They once more received Vinobaji's guidance. Here it was decided that they should return on foot through Uttar Pradesh, spending three or four months on the way. They were in Uttar Pradesh from 2nd. November 1969 till 22nd. February 1970, when they re-entered the Punjab. They stayed in the Prasthan Ashram at Pathankot for about a fortnight and on the 14th. March they set out for Jammu and Kashmir.

In Jammu and Kashmir

The sisters stayed in the city of Jammu for nine days. On 12th. May they reached Srinagar. In Jammu and Kashmir the pilgrimage lasted for about seven months. From both the geographical and cultural points of view this State falls into three regions. Ladakh is in the extreme north, and is entirely a hilly area. Jammu has dry undulating hills. The people of Jammu resemble those of the Punjab. Kashmir is a long and beautiful valley. The sisters would have liked to go to Ladakh, but people dissuaded them by saying that there would be many difficulties on the way and in moving about there. In Jammu and Kashmir, especially in the Kashmir valley, the sisters visited many towns and villages. They met all kinds of people. When they reached Srinagar, communal trouble had been acute in the Kashmir valley for some time. They had to wait there for three weeks. Later the situation slowly improved.

Earlier, many people had told the sisters that they would find a difference in the people of Kashmir due to entirely different conditions there. The atmosphere would be tense and people would not be helpful. Embers

were smouldering and they would be in danger. Although they had been warned in this way, their pilgrimage in Kashmir lasted for seven months. In every Kashmir village they found the same heart filled with love. They found the same good wishes here as they had found in other parts of the country. They found people who were very careful to remove all the difficulties of their pilgrimage. Some people took great care to see that the pilgrims are well-fed.

‘You are Servants of God !’

At many places the sisters received the blessing, “You are Khudai Khidmatgar. May God keep you fit.” Members of all political parties came and talked freely with our sisters. Sheikh Abdullah also came twice to meet them. He was much impressed by the fact that these four sisters were determined to continue the pilgrimage for twelve years. He told them, “I respect your dedication to your aim. You are undergoing great hardships.” Mridula Bahin Sarabhai also was concerned about them.

Many people remembered Vinobaji’s Kashmir pilgrimage of ten years ago and said : “He is a representative of the poor. He has spiritual power and love. Since you have come on his behalf, we have come to meet you. You have no connection with the army, or with any political party or even with the government. You are true servants of God.”

Everywhere the pilgrim sisters were received with love and confidence. The people of Kashmir reminded them of the tribal people of Sargouja. They showed the same

simplicity, purity, motherly love and anxiety to welcome the guests. They also found a good atmosphere of communal unity among the general public. It is true that there are very few vegetarians in Kashmir. In the market, one will find one butcher's shop to every three vegetable shops. Yet on the occasion of religious celebrations Hindus and Muslims, both abstain from eating meat for a week. They also noticed that in Jammu and Kashmir Muslims do not eat beef. They consider the cow sacred, and therefore do not slaughter it. Cow-slaughter is regarded as a sin in Jammu and Kashmir.

The grandeur of Nature

Here nature is luxuriously beautiful. On all sides there are hills, with the valley of Kashmir in their midst. After a fall of snow, the surrounding peaks are white, while the valley looks black by contrast. The crown of snow on the hill-tops, the waterfalls flowing over huge rocks, the rivers Chenab and Jhelum flowing in the valley, clouds floating like fleeced cotton, sometimes above and sometimes below, the musical murmur of the mountain air sighing through the trees, great forest of wild berries with pomegranates, cedar, pine, kel and sapheda trees, chinar trees more than four hundred years old, fruit gardens of cherry, plum, apple, almond, walnut and greengages, as if here nature had laid bare her entire treasures.

In Rajasthan—Desert

Till 16th. October 1970 the pilgrimage continued in Kashmir State with these charming views of nature and

of the human heart. Then again passing through the Punjab for two or three months, the pilgrims entered the desert land of Rajasthan on 1st. January 1971. Here the pilgrimage lasted for about six months. During this time they experienced widely different weather and widely contrasting scenery. They also saw many new things.

They entered Rajasthan through the desert region. An immense sky above, an equally immense desert below. The desert stretched right to the horizon. It seemed as if all sense of direction ended here. Hills and forests have a beauty of their own, but the desert is no less beautiful. The small sand-hills look as if they had been most beautifully arranged.

Big underground Reservoirs

Water is very scarce in Rajasthan. Wells are from three to four hundred feet deep and at places even deeper still. In some villages the water is brackish. In a village in the District of Bikaner drinking water comes from a distance of twentyseven miles. In some places water is sold in the same way as other commodities. The sisters were surprised to see the custom of constructing underground reservoirs in order to store rain water. At one place a pakkah reservoir covered an area of full one bigha (40 × 40 sq. yds.). Here the rainfall is very low. Sometimes four to five years old children are surprised to see rain for the first time in their life. As a matter of fact the soil is fertile. Crops grown during sufficient rain last for two or three years. Besides farming, people depend on dairying. Even in the desert areas the cattle can get nourishment from wild shrubs.

They use the milk of cows, sheep, goats and camels. Camel-carts are also used here.

They entered the desert of Rajasthan in the month of January. They shivered with cold wind blowing over the desert land. Even the dewdrops froze from the intense cold, and a thin white frost covered the ground. These days also passed, and the summer approached. The heat of desert regions is as intense as the cold. The sisters adapted their daily routine according to the weather. They would get up at two and set out on their journey at three o'clock, reaching the day's halt before the heat of the sun became unbearable.

Asking 'Gita Pravachan' at Two

They remember an incident of these days. It was half past two in the morning. The sisters were getting ready to set out on their walk. Just at that time a man arrived with a lantern in his hand and said: "I have come to buy a copy of the 'Gita Pravachan.'" The sisters were most surprised to see a man coming at the dead of night to buy a book. They asked him why he had come at such time. He replied, "I was attending your meeting yesterday. In a life of fortyfive years I have never derived such pleasure as I did from what I heard yesterday. You said that the 'Gita Pravachan' would be helpful to purify our work and to increase our inner harmony. As you are leaving this place at three o'clock, so I have come now to buy the book."

Gradually the weather, and also the scenery began to change. Since long our pilgrims had not seen a blade of grass or a green leaf. But as they drew near the district of

Jaipur, crops of wheat and vegetables began to appear. They learnt that water was available here at a depth of thirty feet. Here they met big business-men trading in Bengal and Assam. These people met the sisters with curiosity, and talked to them in Assamese. Our sisters found that in some villages eighty per cent of the people are doing business in Assam. People from Rajasthan are found in Nepal, Uttar Pradesh, Madras, Mysore, Maharashtra, Bombay, Andhra and Bengal. There is no State in the country where Rajasthanis have not settled.

Here the pilgrim sisters met Acharya Tulsi and some Jain nuns. The Acharya appreciated the pilgrimage and gave his blessings.

After crossing the green belt the pilgrims entered the district of Ajmer where from the Aravali Hills came into sight. At last, they reached Mount Abu. Here they saw the famous Jain temples of Dilwara. From the artistic point of view, the marble-work in these temples is amazing. The pilgrims had thought that Rajasthan was only 'registhan' (desert), but now they realized that it contained green fields and mountains also.

In the Land of Gandhi

As their steps advanced, the temperature gradually became pleasant. Clouds gathered in the sky, and occasionally rain would fall. The land of Mira receded and that of Gandhi approached.

The pilgrim sisters entered the State of Gujarat on 9th. July 1971. They had long cherished a desire to see this land of Gandhi's birth and work. Here they

visited Porbandar, Gandhi's birth-place. They stayed at Sabarmati in Gandhi's Harijan Ashram. Ravishankar Maharaj, the Grand Old Man of Gujarat, accompanied them throughout the Ashram and gave them a living commentary. The sisters spoke in the Sabarmati Jail. Here they saw the rooms in which Bapu and Sardar lived as prisoners. They also stayed at the historic spot of Dandi.

Dwarika, Somnath, Dakore

Gujarat is the land of Lord Krishna as well as that of Gandhi. In Assam there is a belief that Krishna brought Rukmini from Assam to Dwarika. Songs of devotion to Krishna are sung in every house in Assam. Therefore naturally the sisters from Assam were anxious to visit Dwarika. The pilgrims spent two days in that sacred land of Lord Krishna. They were enchanted with the cry of "Long live the Lord of Dwarika" as this cry mingled with the roaring of the great waves at the estuary of the river Gomati. Later they saw the historical temple of Somnath on the sea-shore and also the famous Dakore Temple of Ranchor Rai, a name of Lord Krishna, meaning one who fled from the battle as a strategic measure. (He once fled from the battle-field.)

There was a ten-day halt in Ahmedabad, the capital of Gujarat. Here there are seventy to eighty cloth mills and many factories, big and small. There are also fifty to sixty colleges. Here not only vehicles, but also men, move about at high speed. In this city, Ravishankar Maharaj has organized about fortyfive thousand 'Sarvodaya Patras.'

Baroda is a centre of culture. Shri Aurovindo lived there for some years. Vinobaji spent his childhood here. In 1916 he left home once and for all. For the pilgrim sisters, his house in Baroda was a place of pilgrimage.

The tribal area of Rangpur in Baroda District is famous throughout the country from the point of the awakening of the Gramdani areas. Here we have an example of how to free ourselves from the rule of the police, the court and the money-lender. The sisters were much impressed by the people's court, a unique type of court organized by Shri Hari Vallabh Bhai.

Some Specialities of Gujarat

Gandhi's constructive work has spread throughout Gujarat. Many people have devoted their lives to it. Here there is a special bent for social service. It would be difficult to find so many organizations for social service or so many social workers, both men and women in any other State of India. At many places they saw good organizations of constructive work, and schools of Nai Talim up to the 'Uttar Buniyadi' (college) standard. In Gujarat the sisters also came into close contact with students. Here the students seemed to be quieter and more disciplined than in other parts of the country. They asked the sisters many questions. They were anxious to learn. This was the first non-Hindi State in the course of the pilgrimage. But there was little need for translation anywhere. Generally speaking, even in the villages, people understood the simple Hindi used by our pilgrim sisters.

They found that people in Gujarat are very well behaved, practical and cultured. They are not easily upset. They are clean and tidy and also devout. Not only women, but also men, observe vows and fasts. Barring a few areas, there is less of a gulf between the rich and the poor. The sisters were charmed by the Garba Ras (a form of dance). They still remember the greeting of "Jai Shrikrishna", the New Year greeting of "Sal Mubarak", and the farewell greeting of "Avajo, Avajo".

Inspiring love

The public of Gujarat was also much impressed by the pilgrim sisters. After staying a few days with the pilgrimage a friend wrote, "These sisters are learned, but to my mind many other sisters may be more learned. These sisters are brahmacharinis, but many Jain nuns are also brahmacharinis. But the pure love radiated by these sisters touches the heart. Their faith in and their absorption in their aim is also equally touching. Their simplicity, fearlessness and purity in their contacts with menfolk is remarkable. Their lives are beginning to infuse pure love in the lives of many others."

In Maharashtra

After walking for about nine months in Gujarat, our pilgrims entered Maharashtra on 9th. April 1972. In Maharashtra they followed the line of the Sahyadri Hills and for some days passed through the tribal villages situated at the foot of these hills. This is an area of abject poverty. For days together the diet of these tribal people is confined to flowers of the Mahua tree.

They also make a strong drink from these flowers and are frequently intoxicated by it.

In a thatched cottage

The day following Diwali their halt was in a small village. The pilgrim sisters entered a small thatched cottage with the request : "Some guests have come to your village today. Will you feed them ?"

The woman laughed a pathetic laugh. "Come along. Let us see your house." So saying, they went inside. What did they find there ? Although it was the home of a householder, from the point of view of non-possession, it surpassed that of Jain monks or nuns. Two dirty torn patched quilts in a corner, one or two aluminium pots, a couple of earthen pitchers. One of the sisters put her hand inside a pitcher and found a little pulse in it. The other pitcher was empty. "What did you eat this morning ?" "What will you have at mid-day ?" "What did you give to your children ?" "Do you go out to work ?" In one breath the sisters asked many such questions. The woman replied, "I did not have anything this morning. I don't know about mid-day. If anything turns up, I'll eat it. I go to clean utensils."

"How much a month do you earn by cleaning utensils ?"

"Only ten rupees", she replied.

"What else do you do ?"

"If there is work in the fields, I work on a daily basis, but this year the rains have failed, and hence there is no work".

Such scenes are not uncommon.

For a time the pilgrims passed through the drought-hit areas. The whole earth was parched, not a single blade of green grass ! The sky held out no hope of rain. Sometimes clouds ran into the sky but there was no sign of rain. The Government had initiated relief measures for the famine-stricken people at places in the form of digging tanks, at others building roads. Even this would be at a distance of three or four miles from the villages. In the early morning with their children on their back, women set out to work. They had to remove basketfuls of clay on their head. Still they were not sure about their wages. In the house, not a grain to eat, and no work near at hand in the fields or the villages ! Some had not eaten for a day, some not for two days.

Hearts untouched by Famine

Yet this external famine had not affected the hearts of the people. They were still generous. Thousands of people would gather to meet them every morning and evening. People welcomed the pilgrims with devotional songs and music. They would offer their guests such things which were not available in their homes or in the village.

The womenfolk would come to welcome the pilgrims with a vessel with 'haldi-kunkum', rice, lighted lamp and coconut. Generally women, and sometimes even men, would sprinkle at the feet of their guests water from a pitcher on their head, throw the haldi-kunkum in the air, so that it coloured the sisters as if it were the

time of Holi. Then they would greet them with 'arti.' These ceremonies took ten to fifteen minutes daily. One day they took a full half-hour. Many times people led the sisters in a procession behind students with lezim.

At Sacred Places

The songs of Jnandeo and Tukaram resounded everywhere. In Maharashtra people experience a feeling of purity and blessedness at the very mention of these two great saints. Visitors are always charmed by this devotion. Our sisters also visited Dehu, the birth-place of Tukaram. This is a beautiful and lonely spot of great natural beauty on the banks of the Indrayani river. The pilgrims also stayed at Alandi, where Jnandeo Maharaj, greatest among the saints, took his final samadhi.

Vinobaji was born in the Kolaba District of Maharashtra. The pilgrim sisters saw the tall but simple house of Vinoba's family in the centre of the village of Gagoda. They met Shri Patil, his childhood friend, who is now eighty years old. He said, "Please send Vinoba here. I would like to meet him and see him."

In Dhulia District the sisters were able to meet Shivaji Rao, Vinobaji's youngest brother. They also visited the Dhulia Jail where forty years ago Vinobaji had given his famous talks on the Bhagavad Gita. They also saw the hut in which Sita and Rama are said to have lived on the banks of the river Godavari. In Maharashtra it is considered very auspicious to bathe in the Godavari. This river is considered to be the Ganges of Maharashtra.

In the City of Bombay

The pilgrims reached Bombay on 19th. June 1972 and stayed there for forty days. From one end to the other, the sisters visited every locality. Bombay is a city of rapid movement. There are swift means of transport. The citizens are also racing against time. No one has time to pause. Everybody seems to run. Everywhere there is crowd and crowd. Long queues for the buses, overcrowded buses and trains, cars and taxis continually tearing ! Amidst all these the pilgrim sisters walked on peacefully for forty days.

People welcomed them everywhere. They met people of varying status. Meetings were held for students, teachers, lawyers, labourers, women. All listened to the sisters with love and curiosity. When Lakshmi, from Assam, delivered her speech in Marathi without any hesitation, the tunes of the heart naturally mingled. Everyone felt attracted towards her. There was plenty of propaganda in the city. Information about the pilgrimage was broadcast through newspapers, radio, posters and magazines. Some journalists had special interviews with the sisters and wrote special articles. The film division of the Government of India took a film of the pilgrimage.

One day they had a programme in the Remand Home. Orphans, deserted, criminal and ostracised girls and women live there. They were very happy to meet the pilgrim sisters. They all discussed their problems for hours.

A Touching Meeting

The most touching programme in Bombay was their meeting with prostitutes. The public regards them as

fallen. So-called civilized people live at a respectable distance from them. But how could our sisters avoid meeting them ? They went to meet them. They expressed their sympathy towards these unfortunate sisters. Here are some important questions and answers:

"Why did you adopt this profession ?"

"I had to adopt it to earn my living."

"How much were you educated ?"

"No education." (Only one Christian girl was educated upto the eighth standard.)

"Do you meet your relatives ?"

"People consider us fallen, so we don't keep contact with anyone. We sometimes go to our villages and we also send money to our families. Our neighbours don't know how we earn our living."

"How long have you been in this profession ?"

"Some of us for seven years, some for ten years, and some have just come."

"Can't you strive to improve and lead a life like others ?"

"That doesn't seem possible in this birth. People think that we are fallen."

There were some fallen sisters who observed vows and daily worship. The pictures of gods were hanging on their walls.

The pilgrim sisters told them why they had come to see them. They said :

तुलसी या संसार में सबसे मिलिये धाय ।

ना जाने का भेस में नारायण मिल जाय ॥

"Saint Tulsi Das said, 'Hasten to meet everybody in this world, for we do not know in which form God may

appear before us.' We are out to seek where and in what form we may meet God."

The sisters then affectionately fondled each girl's head. Every girl put her hand in the hands of each sister and they welcomed them with cocacola. That was a touching scene.

Prosperity and Poverty

In Bombay our sisters could well see the prosperity created by man. But in this city there is also no lack of man-made pauperism and poverty. On the one hand there are twentyfive to thirty-storied sky scrapers, on the other hand are slums with thousands of people sleeping on the footpath. It was the rainy season. The pilgrim sisters could see that when it rained, huts would begin leaking and floor would be drenched. In a small hut of 8' x 8' or 8' x 10', there would be the whole world of a married couple and their children. It was their bedroom, drawing-room and kitchen also. There is no end to the disparity created by man.

After Bombay there was a six-day halt at Poona city. In Maharashtra, Poona is regarded as a city of learning and culture. The sisters spent eleven days in Ahmednagar, and then moved on towards Wardha. They still remember an incident which occurred at a village near Wardha. A girl suddenly fainted. In this unconscious condition she called sometimes her mother and sometimes her father. Many people came to offer help. The doctor was also called. But the girl was not improving. Her father sat beside her. Whenever the girl cried or called her father and mother, the father

would calmly say, "My child, Now we cannot help you. Remember God, and God alone." How true ! He alone can remove our burdens.

With Vinoba

Walking through eleven districts of Maharashtra for eight months, the pilgrims came to Vinobaji at Pavnar on 1st. December. They had completed about five years of their pilgrimage. They had thought of spending some time with Vinobaji before moving on. They stayed at Pavnar uptill 12 th. February. They took advantage of the company of Vinobaji and his brother Balkobaji. Mutual bonds of love arose from their intimate contact with the sisters of the Brahma Vidya Mandir.

Vinobaji addressed the pilgrim sisters, "These five years of your pilgrimage have been only a preparation. In ensuing seven years you have to make your hearts pure, and clean impurities. 'On a foot pilgrimage for twelve years !' 'Educated women !' 'Brahmacharinis !' 'They have been walking for five years !' 'They have traversed twelve thousand miles'—People will regard you in this way ! They will form a high opinion of you. Every day you should introspect, "What mistakes have we made today ?" In this way, every day we must eliminate our short-comings. In the days of Mahatma Buddha, animal sacrifice was a part of 'yagna'. He opposed the practice of animal-sacrifice and expounded compassion. Bhudan-Gramdan has been granted us as a means. We have to propagate devotion on this basis. Thus social education will automatically prosper. But that is incidental. The important thing is to feel that God is

Omnipresent and that we are wandering in search of Him.”

Towards South India

With these instructions the sisters once more set out on their pilgrimage on 12th. February 1973. After walking for about three weeks through Maharashtra, they entered Andhra State on 5th. March. The pilgrimage now turned towards South India. So far it had been in the North and West and our pilgrims had been using the Hindi language. In Gujarat and Maharashtra there was little need for translation. In Maharashtra Lakshmi could talk directly in Marathi. But in the South there are four new languages. Here their speeches will have to be translated.

Yet the hearts of the people still remain the same. Everywhere in Andhra the pilgrims have been welcomed with the same affection and enthusiasm. In the midst of variety and diversity the sisters are inspired by the vision of the heart of the people, which gives them the strength to walk on. This pilgrimage is continuing even today on this inspiration and strength. From one village to the next, from one district to the next, from one State to the next, they have to walk on and on. Charaiveti ! Charaiveti !—The mantra fructifies : Walk ! walk thou ! walk on ! ●

Reviving Women's Power

"Where have you four sisters come from?"

"From Assam, from Delhi, and from Madhya Pradesh. We have come to meet you."

"What relations have you at home?"

"We have mothers, brothers, sisters and sisters-in-law. But they are all thousands of miles away. Today you are our mothers, these are our brothers."

"But your husband? Your children?"

"None of us is married."

"What! You're not married? How can a woman live alone? Unmarried? Why haven't you married?"

"Service is the greatest thing for human being. Is there more than this in marriage? And think for a while, today we can wander from village to village and meet you all. Could we have gone about like this if we had married?"

"Are you walking alone?"

"No, where are we alone? We are all four together."

"But You have no *man* with you?"

"No, what is the need? We are four, inspite of that you think that we are alone, because women have considered themselves the weaker sex."

High Aim of Life

Such a discussion takes place in almost every village. The sisters emphasize this point, especially in women's meetings, and explain to them in detail. The substance of their speech before women usually is that marriage should never be the be-all and end-all of a woman's life. The aim of both men and women must be a high one—social service and the realization of God. Whether or not a woman marries, she should be self-dependent. She should not depend on men. This is a big mistake that women regard themselves as helpless. Women have a great power—that of bearing and creating men. An innocent child trusts its mother. If the mother says, this is the sun, the moon, water, the child naturally accepts it. He does not say that he will first test it out and then believe what his mother says. So we must recognize this mother-power of building a man. Yet it is women themselves who are blocking the road of women's progress. If a son is born, they celebrate the occasion, but if a girl is born, they grieve. Women themselves have no respect for women. They will bring up a son in one way, a daughter in another way. If a boy is afraid to go out in the dark, they will say, "You are a boy, yet you are afraid to go out!" And if a girl wants to go out alone, far from encouraging her, they will try to break her courage. So long as these different policies are followed, women will remain helpless. In our society a man may remain a brahmachari, but women have no such right. Women will become self-dependent only when they are free to observe brahmacharya and restraint, otherwise they will remain dependent upon men.

Today the marriage of a daughter is a great problem for her parents. Why? Because a dowry has to be provided.

Woman's Value

This topic starts an interesting dialogue. In the meeting the sisters ask, "When a certain commodity is in short supply in the market, does its price rise or fall?"

"Yes, of course, it rises."

"Then why is woman priced so cheaply? The law of the market is that if a commodity is scarce, its price rises. Today, in India, there are 932 women to every thousand men. It means that there are 68 women less than men. So should not the price of woman rise? From this point of view, women should be dearer than men. But on the contrary, their price does not rise, it is not even equal."

Sometimes a woman gets up and asks "Is not the service of her husband a woman's highest duty?"

"For centuries women have been taught that a wife who serves her husband will achieve liberation. We can believe this in the sense that God is incarnate in man. But is He not incarnate in everyone? Is He not incarnate in women? Then why do we not say that a husband who serves his wife will achieve liberation? A man may remain a Brahmachari or become a Sannyasi. But woman? She can only remain a woman, a wife. Why this difference? Has woman no soul? Is she not a human being? Are we human beings first or men and women first?"

"We are human beings first."

"Then tell us, should there be one law for human beings or two?"

"One."

Women to be self-protected

Today, women have no spiritual rights in our society. We have to achieve these rights. The aim of life should be not to obtain a suitable man, a husband, but to achieve salvation. Instead of decorating your body, seek out the soul in man. Woman can become self-reliant only on the basis of spiritual strength. Women should not be protected, they should be self-protected.

On hearing this talk, a mother at Bombay said, "My daughter is refusing to marry. I was not heeding her. What you have said today appeals to me. Now I shall not force her to marry."

The pilgrim sisters observed that everywhere women have a deep longing for liberation. But does anyone try to understand their feelings? What a longing they have to achieve wisdom and to pass beyond the joys and sorrows of life. But the position is that they do not fully understand their own wishes. They have spent generations and generations imprisoned behind the veil, they have forgotten the joys of open air. They are delighted when our pilgrim sisters discuss all these matters with them. Their hidden hunger awakes. Sometimes a young woman comes in the evening after dark and says, "I have come secretly. I wanted to attend the mid-day meeting, but my husband and my mother-in-law do not allow me to go anywhere. Now

I have come to meet you on the pretext of answering the call of nature." Sometimes when our sisters go to the river or the pond to bathe, other women come there to fill water or wash clothes or to bathe. Naturally, they exchange ideas.

World : a Temple of Knowledge

Once our pilgrim sisters were staying in a Punjabi family. The mother of the family was talking, "By the grace of God, I am not worried about my bread and butter. Nor am I worried about the children. As a mother, I have to fulfil my responsibility of bringing them up. I am fulfilling that. I have no anxiety to amass a fortune or to wear jewellery. All that would be a nuisance. By God's grace I can fulfil my responsibilities, but living the householder's life, how can I cross the threshold?"

This 'mother' had been married at fourteen and at fifteen she had become a mother. She is still young, but she has five children. Yet even submerged in the depths of the world, she was at peace. She was also somewhat detached. What could the pilgrim sisters suggest? They asked, "How have you achieved this wisdom?" A slightly humorous smile lit up that peaceful face. "Sister, the world is a great teacher, and then there is the bent of conscience."

To the seeker, this world is a temple of wisdom. Practical experience is the text-book of this temple of wisdom. Our sisters have met the women of different walks of life in different States. Many of them are anxious to achieve wisdom and anxious for liberation.

Woman: a Saint

Patricia, an English lady joined the pilgrimage for some days in Maharashtra. In meetings, she always asked the women : "In every Indian home there is a saint. Do you know who that saint is? That saint is the mother of the family. A saint is one who lives not for himself but for others. In an Indian family, that is what the mother does. She lives not for herself but for others." Patricia was very much impressed by Indian women. She used to say that we cannot find these emotions of Indian women in the women of other parts of the world.

Once a poor woman of Rajasthan narrated an incident. She said : "Sisters, I was pregnant. At that time I had a great craving to eat jalebis. But as we were two, and we had two children, how could we arrange jalebis for all the four of us? I suppressed that craving. One day"—while describing this her voice was choked with emotion,—“my five-year old daughter came to me and said ‘mother, you want to take some jalebis? But you cannot have them, because of us. Today I will take my small brother out to play and then you take your jalebis.’ This opened my eyes. My little girl, possessing so much self-restraint! And I, her mother, cannot restrain myself? My craving for jalebis came to an end. I was content!” Our sisters were greatly moved to hear this.

Sarvodaya in the Family

They had a similar experience in Gujarat. At breakfast time they gave fruits and biscuits to a working

woman. She wrapped them all up in a paper. Our sisters insisted her to eat them. To satisfy them she put a small piece of a biscuit in her mouth, wrapped up the rest and took them away. "There are four more hungry mouths to feed", she said. This is sarvodaya in the family.

The same thing may hold good for a village, for all. We should feel that every hungry mouth in our neighbourhood is ours. Then we will enjoy restraint and sacrifice.

Once their halt happened to be in a small hut. Everyone was working in the fields. There was only one woman who lived nearby. When she heard of the pilgrim sisters' arrival, she came straight to them. She had some bananas and a little sugar in her hand. After chatting a little, she reluctantly went to work. But what did she do on reaching her field? She roasted some groundnuts, and tying them in a bundle brought them to give to our sisters. She went back again. In the evening she again arrived. Then she went back to her house. She cooked a porridge of rice and pulse, with millet bread and curds, and brought it for the sisters. To eat alone, to work only for oneself is not a happy life. Joy comes from feeding others. The pilgrim sisters have very often met such women full of love who experience greater joy in feeding others.

Are they Ignorant ?

They have also found that there is no lack of understanding in these ordinary village-women. One day four or five women were talking amongst themselves. One

woman was explaining to another, "What does Rama mean ? Rama was an incarnation, we worship the image of Rama, that is all right in its own place, but in fact Rama means peace, compassion, love." Then a second woman asked. "What does Ravana mean ?" The first replied, "Ravana means anger, jealousy." This is the commentary of uneducated village-women on the Ramayana. Who can call such women ignorant ?

One incident more ! Often some woman complains about her husband or mother-in-law, our sisters advice her with some indignation, "Don't bow down. Don't be afraid. If your husband doesn't agree, tell him frankly that his way and your way are apart." Once when such a discussion was going on, a village-woman said emphatically, "Sister, you know nothing about this. In the home we have both to talk and to listen. If ways were so easily parted, no one would be able to live with anyone else."

Fearlessness necessary

A woman may be confined to the home, or she may be free to move about, she may be educated or illiterate, she may be rich or poor, her motherly love and affection is the strength of the family. The qualities of sacrifice and self-suffering are present in all women. This a natural gift to them. Whether city-women or village women, today they are all awakening. Educated women are craving for freedom. But they think that freedom means merely freedom to behave just like men. They do not seem to realize the fearlessness and self-reliance which freedom calls for. Village-women seem to have

more courage than city-women. In the villages it is still an every-day occurrence to be beaten by a drunken husband. Women have not yet been able to escape from this evil. But village-women now have the courage to stand up and speak in a big meeting. If mistakes are being committed in the village, they have the courage to condemn them. City-women seem to be far more helpless than village-women.

In the tribal areas of Sargouja, the women-folk mixed with our sisters very freely. They would come and sit along with men in public meetings. Sometimes they accompanied them on the walk. Sometimes they assumed full responsibility for the arrangement of the pilgrimage.

In other areas, women do not come out in public so easily. Arrangements for the pilgrimage were in the hands of women only in Himachal Pradesh and Gujarat. In other places, the arrangements were entirely in the hands of men.

Purdah, Burqah and Ornaments

Due to the purdah system in Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan, the condition of women is miserable. In these States girls are married early and they are not much educated. The child-marriage, dowry and lack of education have hindered the progress of women. They have a fascination for ornaments. In the name of ornaments, women in these parts carry a burden of two or three kilos on their hands, feet and waist. In almost every village the pilgrim sisters oppose the purdah system. They say: "Why do you put on all this? Cast

away this veil. Have you done anything wrong? Why do you cover your face like this? And why do you carry this burden of ornaments? Look at the filth these ornaments have accumulated!"

Muslim women are imprisoned in the burqah. Their plight is even worse. The Hindu, Sikh and other women may go to a temple or gurudwara, but since Muslim women may not go to the mosque for namaz, they have few opportunities of getting out of their homes. The pilgrim sisters met some women who regard the burqah as the emblem of religion, and therefore cannot conceive of the possibility of giving it up. But in some other places Muslim women vehemently opposed the burqah. Some Muslim women said, "Hindus can legally have only one wife. We approve of this. In Islam, four wives are permitted. This is wrong." In Kashmir our sisters found that barring middle-class women, there is very little of the burqah in the poor and the upper classes. In some places in Maharashtra also Muslim women came to meetings without the burqah.

The Modern Form of Slavery

The pilgrim sisters always attack these bad customs and explain that in the pomp and show of ornaments and dress woman has lost her personality. By decorating herself she adds to her slavery. Women in the Punjab observe less of purdah, instead of this they are falling a prey to the slavery of the club. The blind imitation of modern civilization is making them greater slaves. They are extremely fond of modern fashion, up-to-date clothes and ornaments. Even the village-women use lip-stick!

The pilgrim sisters found that in comparison to Punjabi women, Gujarati women are generally more simple. Though they do not use many ornaments, they also wish to keep ornaments. Here, women are given greater opportunities of education. They are well-versed in the art of cooking. They prepare a variety of chutneys, pickles, jams and papad. They also keep their houses clean and tidy. They spend a large portion of their time in kitchen and household work.

In Gujarat and Maharashtra there are Mahila Mandals and many other women's organizations in the cities and towns.

These organizations also do some educational work. They do some practical work in the form of tailoring, preparing papad and so on. In spite of all this, no solid work is being done for the awakening of women in the real sense. Even in Gujarat there is a considerable number of women suicides. Women have not yet been able to overcome their weaknesses. They have not become self-reliant. No attention has been paid to their basic problems. The Mahila Mandal activities are limited to a few women. Most women are not interested in them. To arouse women we need a change in their attitude and their approach to themselves.

This is the work of the pilgrimage. It is very important to approach the country-women and awaken them. As women, our pilgrim sisters are able to reach the kitchen. They are at home in the family. Women also talk freely with them. They also attend their meetings and are never tired of listening to them.

Today woman's power lies hidden. She has not recognized it. When woman realizes her own-self, she will be able to break her inner and outer fetters and give a lead to society. We have to revive women's power. Charaiveti ! Charaiveti !—Walk ! Walk thou ! Walk on !

●

What do the Pilgrims say ?

“Think of the people’s welfare daily.”—This is the mantra which Vinobaji has given to the pilgrim sisters. They have always to walk, with the thought of the welfare of the people. They must reach the people to give them the message of revolution. Thus the pilgrimage continually carries the message of folk-education. They meet people of every status of society and of every trade and occupation. While emphasizing their own viewpoints, the sisters highlight some important aspects applicable to different types of people. Here we reproduce as specimen some extracts from the speeches of the pilgrim sisters.

To Students

The future rests in your hands. The responsibility for making or marring the world rests on you. You will have to live in the world which you create. That world should not be a carbon copy of today’s world. In that new world there should be neither poverty nor unemployment, nor inequality nor war. Will you follow the beaten track or carve out a new path ?

‘Tarun’ means one who leads to deliverance. One who himself achieves deliverance and helps others to



Hem Bahin addressing a Women's meeting

A Call to revive Women's Power



achieve it will not depend on others. He will not be led astray by politicians. Youth will study different ideologies and will adopt a new way to change the world.

To Teachers

In our country, teachers have been highly respected. It is our good fortune that our teachers have always functioned as the guides of society. They walked throughout the country and gave good advice to the people, who respected and obeyed them. Indian culture, literature and religion flourished because of these Acharyas. These teachers knew that the power of the State is limited and that education is the only means to re-construct society.

But today teachers have forgotten their role and have adopted that of an ordinary civil servant. To remind them of their potentialities as well as of their duties, Vinobaji has developed the idea of the Acharya Kul. This will be an organization of teachers, not to fight for selfish ends or rights, but to contribute towards social re-construction.

Teacher is the builder of the coming generation. But just as the musk-deer is not conscious of its musk, today the teacher is not conscious of his real strength. Education should be free from all official control. It must not be under the control of continually changing governments. Politicians are elected by the people only for five years, whereas a teacher can work for thirty or forty years for the re-construction of society. Therefore, education should be as free from governmental control as the judiciary is.

To Doctors

A doctor is an artist. His duty is to serve society through his art. His task is to keep people healthy, happy and free from all diseases. This is not merely a profession. The work of a doctor is to serve, not to earn money or lead an easy life.

Nor is the task of a doctor fulfilled merely by writing prescriptions. Patients will have to understand why they have fallen ill. A doctor's success cannot be gauged by the large number of his patients. The success of a doctor consists in decreasing the incidence of disease. Therefore a doctor's main responsibility is education in balanced diet. A doctor's work includes educating people in the rules of health, and imparting knowledge about balanced diet, mental health and a life of restraint. The health of any society will depend on the extent to which it co-operates in this.

Doctors should also help patients to become self-dependent with regard to medicine. Herbs and medicines available in the village should be used as much as possible. Why insist on any 'pathy'? The highest pathy is 'sympathy'.

To Lawyers

The real work of lawyers is not merely the disposal of legal cases, but to see that justice is done. Where there is justice, there is less chance of dispute. Otherwise, on the one hand law courts will increase and on the other hand crime. A man commits a crime and the law court punishes him. Does that settle the matter? We must go into the root cause of the crime. Why and under

what conditions did he commit the crime ? Unless these conditions are changed, crime cannot be lessened. Therefore, lawyers have a great responsibility for social justice and social health.

This is the aim of the movement initiated by Vinobaji. The roots of injustice and exploitation must be eradicated. We have to create conditions which prevent disputes or dissensions from arising in a village, but if they do arise at any time, the villagers themselves must settle them. Vinobaji has given the villagers the slogan 'freedom from the quarrel shop' (the law/court). You too have to help in this revolution for social change. During the days of struggle for independence all great leaders were lawyers. Why should not lawyers come forward today ?

Justice is becoming increasingly costly and more difficult to obtain. This not only robs the poor, but also deprives them of justice. This state of affairs must also be improved. Lawyers should become protectors of the poor. They should also do their work fearlessly and in such a way as to inspire confidence. Today it is said that a lawyer's profession is a liar's profession. Lawyers have to wipe out this stigma.

To Business-men

While we were walking in Rajasthan we were told that certain commodities were not available there and only rich people could buy them. But since businessmen came there these commodities are available to all and at cheap rates. What a great service this is ! That is why business has been regarded as a religious duty.

Business-men have been called 'mahajans' that is, 'great men'. They have been respected in society.

But today there appears to be great public indignation against business-men. They have earned a bad reputation through adulteration in all and sundry goods through the tendency to profiteer and to exploit situations, such as famines, for selfish ends. Therefore, business-men have once more to emphasize honesty in all dealings. Only then can they regain their former prestige in society.

(At times you donate money in charity, but this is not sufficient. The demand of the age is equality. The distinction between rich and poor must be eradicated. You have to participate in this work of social change.

To Industrialists

Gandhi talked of trusteeship. Gramdan is a form of trusteeship. We shall have to develop some form of trusteeship for mills and factories in cities. The times are changing. Capital, labour and organization can now no longer remain antagonistic. Their mutual rivalry is harmful to society. Today, collaboration between capital, labour and organization is essential. Treat labour as your partner and fulfil your responsibilities to society. This is the call of the times and therefore it is bound to come. The only point is that if this is effected not through violence but through goodwill, hearts will be united and moral standards will rise.

To Labourers

The traditional Indian belief is that the earth rests on the hood of Shesh Nag (the great Serpent god).

Similarly the prosperity of a society depends on its labourers.

We see the beautiful fruits and flowers of a tree, but we pay no heed to its roots. This is the condition of our labourers. Why is this so ? Because labourers are not aware of their own power and are not organized.

Gandhi wanted to evolve some new form of labour organizations, but that could not be achieved. Therefore, our labour organizations are copying the trade unions of the West.

The path of Gandhi and Vinoba is one of synthesis, not conflict. Here the achievement of power is possible only through service, renunciation and restraint. Vinobaji says that the distinction between 'haves' and 'have-nots' is wrong in itself. There are no 'have-nots'. All are 'haves'. The labourer has no capital, but he has the capacity to work, and all have love and sympathy. Capitalists will offer capital, labourers will offer labour. Every one has to give something for society. Let every man look not to those above him, but to those below him. Only thus can we develop strength, and only thus can we realize the demand for equality.

To Corporators

You are senior servants of the city. You wish to administer the town well. But it is wrong in essence to think that only a few people can administer the town. Just as we talk of 'gram-swarajya' for villages, we shall also have to talk of 'nagar-swarajya' for cities. Public initiative is essential. Every citizen should contribute to the administration and development of the city with

his emotional, intellectual and physical powers. For this purpose local committees and neighbourhood groups will have to be constituted. When the citizens become active the corporators will have an easy task.

The administration of a city should be carried on on a non-partisan basis. There should be no place for political manoeuvring. We wish to eliminate party politics at all stages, but in the work of a corporation there is absolutely no place for a partisan attitude. Vinobaji says that it is a betrayal of the people and the country to encourage party spirit in a corporation.

Therefore, you all have to administer the city jointly. You have to create an atmosphere of harmony and unity in the city. This unity should be both, intellectual and emotional. Prayer meetings of all religions and other such cultural functions can encourage this. Today in our cities and towns, many people live on the footpath. So in 'nagar-swarajya' the first task will be to provide work and shelter for all. None should remain hungry or naked. As senior servants of the city, all this responsibility falls on your shoulders.

To Government Servants

You and we belong to the same class. When you join government service you are told that in the fulfilment of your duties you have to remain above all considerations of caste, religion, party or sect. We also do not believe in such distinctions. We must always regard man as man and serve him without any kind of distinction. In this respect we are all here in the same category.

We have established 'loka-t-antra' in our country. But so far we have only the element of the 'tantra' and not of the 'loka'. You sustain this system. Thus the public will realize the present extent of democracy through your work. Today there is a gulf between the people and the tantra. This gulf has to be bridged and the tantra must be brought to the people. This is your work. Let people feel that this is no alien administration, but their own.

Most of our people are poor, illiterate. They are being crushed in every way, exploited from all quarters. In these conditions where can they look for help ? This democracy of ours is being run in the name of the majority of these poor people. Therefore naturally, since you are the means of this system, it is your duty to help these poor people and protect them from injustice and exploitation.

You should extend your wholehearted co-operation to our movement which strikes at the root of injustice and exploitation.

To Panchayats

The panchayat is an ancient institution of India. It was autonomous and self-dependent. Our country has endured for so long only on this basis. It was due to this panchayat institution that in spite of so many foreign invasions our villages remained unaffected. The British saw this and in order to establish their empire here, they deliberately disintegrated this strong organization of our villages.

Gandhi knew this. Therefore, he advised people to

revive the tradition of panchayats in our villages. After independence the Government established panchayat rajya. But since this was introduced from above, the public considered it alien and official. People do not regard it as their own. Instead, owing to the invasion of party politics and majority-minority considerations, today many panchayats have become arena of politics. Consequently, village life is becoming disrupted.

You all know this. You also know that Vinobaji is trying to revive our panchayat institution in the real sense of the term. He says that every village must become a family and we must establish 'gram-swarajya' in every village. Our villages will not survive unless they are organized in this way. Therefore, you must all join this movement and develop your village in the direction of 'gram-swarajya.' Through this programme we have to bring about a total change in political and economic spheres and in planning.

To the Police

Your work is the maintenance of peace. It is your responsibility to maintain law and order in society. Sometimes you have to fulfil this responsibility even at the cost of your life. You use force for the maintenance of peace, but you have orders to make the minimum use of force.

We Sarvodaya 'shanti sainiks' are also working for peace. We wish to see peace maintained in society and simultaneously to trace out and eliminate conflict. If at any time conflict does arise, we have to jump into that conflict and restore peace. For this, Gandhi and

Vinoba have placed the programme of the Shanti Sena before the public. This is not a programme of suppression but of pacification. It involves the use not of force but of loving persuasion and sacrifice. We wish that the police should not be needed at all for the maintenance of peace. Later, your work will be to help citizens to help themselves and to maintain law and order. Let us all get together to found such a social order.

To Soldiers

You are defending and reconstructing the country. In time of war you go to the front to lay down your life, and in time of peace you do some form of constructive work. In time of calamity such as earthquake or flood you rush to help us. Bravery is your highest virtue. With the call of '*jai Jawan, jai Kisan*' Shastriji honoured you in a befitting manner.

Vinobaji too has given the mantra "Be Vir and Mahavir." In non-violence there is no place for cowardice. You know that modern wars are not fought only on the battlefront, they are 'total' wars. The defeat or victory of an army depends on the morale of the citizens. The higher the morale of the people, the easier the work of the army.

Internal strength, the elimination of poverty, ignorance and inequality, of differences of language, religion and state; village organization, a self-reliant public, are all essential for the security of the country. These are the objectives of the 'gramdan gram-swarajya' movement. Vinobaji has rightly called 'gramdan' a "defence

measure." You should pay full attention to this great task of defending and reconstructing the country and should also give your full co-operation.

To Prisoners

The only difference between you and us is that you are inside the four walls whereas we are outside. But we are all prisoners, prisoners of our own minds and hence there is no difference between us.

We all commit mistakes at every step. One person's mistake is obvious, another's not. One is punished, while the other is not.

There is a story about Jesus Christ. People were stoning a woman. Jesus asked why they were stoning her. They replied that the woman had committed adultery, that she was a prostitute and that they would therefore kill her in this way. Jesus said that they were free to stone her, but on one condition. One who had never committed any sin should cast the first stone. None dared to cast a stone. To the woman Jesus said, 'Sister go and sin no more' !

We all commit mistakes and to that extent we are all prisoners of our own minds. We are all bound with the same chains. The most difficult task is to escape from the prison of one's own mind. Even after release from gaol, you may still be in the prison of your mind. You will achieve true release only when your mind is bent upon achieving freedom from it.

You can make an effort for this kind of release even while you are in gaol. Then this place will not remain a gaol for you, it will become a temple. There is no

mistake, no sin, in the world, which cannot be washed away. This is why Balia became Valmiki and Angulimala became a sadhu. The bagis (rebels of Chambal Valley) who surrendered to Vinobaji have become good citizens. You may also transform your life. We pray that All-merciful God may inspire you all to bring such a change in your lives.

To Rotarians

You all belong to the respectable and educated class of society. You join this club so that while doing your own business you may also do some social service. This is a proof that man cannot live by bread alone. Man cannot be satisfied merely with material wealth, nor is he content with physical comfort and pleasure. He wishes to do something more. It is this inspiration which brings you here.

A friend tells us that you adopt a village. This is a very good idea. You try to reform your adopted village into an ideal village. But what do you mean by an ideal village ? You make arrangements for sanitation of the village, you arrange to educate the village children. You must certainly do all this. But this alone will not suffice to make an ideal village. Material development by itself is not enough. You will have to see how far the villagers have become human. Have quarrels of the village come to an end ? Have differences of caste, class and creed come to an end ? Has untouchability disappeared ? Do people share one another's joys and sorrows as brothers ? Is the village developing in the direction of a village family ? This is the development in real sense of

the term, We need both material development combined with individual development of the heart. This attitude must underlie all social work.

You must also co-operate in the revolution which Vinobaji has initiated to bring about a total change in society. This is the task of building up an ideal society. As a respected and educated citizen it is your duty to forward this work.

To Journalists

Today almost all newspapers are owned by capitalists. So these newspapers propagate capitalist values. You also frequently become tools in the hands of the capitalists. You may wish to write in a free and impartial way, yet you have to face many kinds of pressure.

Our country is a democratic country. In a country as such we need fearless journalism. Wherever there are mistakes they must be pointed out. The public should be awakened with regard to many questions. The people are the basis of democracy. If the people are not educated, how will democracy function? Newspapers have a major hand in creating public opinion. So the responsibility for creating healthy public opinion rests upon you.

Many newspapers publish sensational news, and many important events of social significance are ignored. For instance, let us take Vinobaji's movement. For the last twenty years a novel type of peaceful revolution such as has never before been seen in the history of the world, has been going on in our country. Fortyfive lakh acres

of land has been donated in Bhoodan. Twelve lakh acres of this land have already been distributed among the landless. Thousands of villages have taken the gramdan pledge. Gramdan Acts have been passed. Many gramdan villages have been legally gazetted. We do not know how far you are aware of this. Your papers give very little space for such news. We only wish to say that Indian newspapers have not fulfilled their duty with regard to this movement. We request you to make a fuller study of the movement and do your bit for it.

To Khadi Workers

Khadi work means building a Sarvodaya Samaj. Today, society is replete with violence. This violence cannot be eradicated until a new society is built up. Man can live free from violence only in a society which is free from disparity. Such a society is the Sarvodaya society. Khadi has to help in the task of building it up.

There is a revolutionary thought behind your work. Khadi is a prop to the helpless, a staff to the lame and a means to protect the virtue of poor and widowed women. In addition it is also a means of creating a non-exploitative and non-violent social order. Please recognize this revolutionary aspect of khadi. You should understand the depth of your work.

Your work is not merely a job or a profession. You have to perform it not with a mercenary but with a missionary spirit. Here there is no difference of employer and employed. If you understand the great thought behind your work the public will appreciate your work,

you yourself will appreciate it and your self-respect will also increase.

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Thus the task of educating the people through the pilgrimage continues. Everywhere people from every level of society come together in large numbers to listen to the sweet voice of our pilgrims. With a vision of God in the form of the people and working for the people's welfare, they walk on continually. Charaiveti ! Charaiveti !!—Walk ! Walk thou ! Walk on !

The Feet move On

Dada Dharmadhikari frequently tells a story about Abraham Lincoln. Once he was taken out in a big procession. Crowds had gathered on both sides of the road to see him. A little child had come there with his mother. He had never seen Lincoln. As Lincoln came nearer, the mother said to her child, "Baby, look, there goes Abraham Lincoln." When the child saw him he said, "Mummy, he looks a simple man. You used to tell me that he is a great man."

God prefers Simple Folk

Lincoln overheard these words. He immediately went to the child and patting him on the back, said, "My dear child ! God prefers ordinary simple looking folk. That is why He has created so many simple folk in this world."

Our pilgrim sisters also are quite simple to look at. They are just ordinary. They are neither very learned, nor have they performed great sadhana. They frequently tell people, "We are ordinary human beings like you. But we are fortunate because we have come to

you as messengers of a great man. We do not know why we have been selected for this work. Perhaps, as Lord Ganesh ignored all the larger animals and chose a little rat as his vehicle, similarly we ordinary women have been chosen as vehicles for this work. Otherwise, we have no special qualifications."

These sisters are very much touched by people's love and affection for them. Every village gives a warm welcome to these pilgrims. At many places, people remember Vinobaji's pilgrimage. People are enthusiastic about this pilgrimage which has to carry Vinobaji's ideas far and wide. People gladly meet the pilgrim sisters and hear what they say. Sometimes the sisters begin to wonder: "Are we, ordinary women, worthy of such extraordinary love? How much faith people have in us! We imperfect people are unable to offer anything to our brethren in return. Had we been perfect, we could give them something."

A Vision of the People

Once the sisters enquired Vinobaji about this doubt. He humourously said, "Yes, you will first become perfect, and then perform service. Have you calculated how many births will this take? If you have decided about the time for becoming perfect all right, you may wait. But this much is certain, that until you become perfect, you will continue to need your daily bread. Then why not think that since you must eat and people around you must feed you, it is better to serve them in whatever way you can? If you decide that until you achieve perfection you will not eat, that is a

different matter. Gautama Buddha sat for forty days in deep meditation; he had undertaken a fast. If your sadhana is so intense that you realize the self, that is all right. But if you daily eat and combine it with slow sadhana, it is your duty to perform service at the same time. People give you so much respect and love because of the great message you are carrying. The high respect for you in the heart of people would be a means to raise you higher."

The pilgrim sisters say that Vinobaji has thus pointed out us the duty of ordinary persons like ourselves to undertake individual sadhana while serving others. The pilgrim sisters move about quite carefree in this respect. God is Omnipresent. They feel that they are walking for a vision of Him. The object of this vision of the people is self-realization and the vision of God. They experience a form of joy in meeting people. They approach people with love and they find that love reciprocated in the eyes of the people. A congregation of people can arouse the same kind of inspiration as an idol of God. The pure feelings emanating from the eyes of the people also purify the sister's feelings. The faith in the eyes of the people strengthens their heart. Such a vision of the people must eventually lead to self-realization.

Gift of Purification

This service of the people gives rise to a different outlook. We have to approach people not with a view to serve them, but with a view of self-purification. We have to approach people as a means of settling the debt which we owe to our society. People come to us with pure heart and we learn much from them.

The pilgrim sisters daily observe that people offer them the best they have. People always give them every comfort even at the cost of their own sacrifice. Their help eliminates poverty of heart and teaches how to enlarge the heart. This is true education. This pilgrimage is an education in the purification of the mind.

Our pilgrim sisters feel that in order to realize both oneself and the Lord, we have not to turn away from people, but have to go amongst them. We have to enter hearts and realize the God enthroned there. Achieving the vision of Narayana, that is God, in the spirit of the people, this pilgrimage has been continuing for the last five years.

A Unique Pilgrimage

Truly, this is a unique pilgrimage. Jain nuns do live on pilgrimage, yet they stay at one place during the monsoons, and even when on pilgrimage they hardly achieve such intimate contact with the people. Many women go on pilgrimage to the four sacred places and walk around the holy place of Vrindavan, but they do not come into such close contact with the people, and moreover, their pilgrimage is much shorter. Whereas, these sisters have set out on a pilgrimage for twelve years, depending completely on the people. They have to wander in their midst. They have no individual or personal life. Every moment has to be spent in public, no privacy of any sort. This in itself is a great achievement. This kind of life may be natural for a saint like Vinobaji, but for ordinary people like them this becomes a special sadhana. The pilgrim sisters have now become used to

this life. Their pilgrimage is a great mission inspired by a great man. This missionary spirit gives strength to their feet.

This is an original idea springing from the astonishing genius of Vinobaji. These sisters have come before society with a mission of service. Through the Kasturba Trust many sisters are today working throughout the country. Women have taken part in the movements initiated by Gandhi and Vinoba. But this continual pilgrimage to the people for the sake of self-realization and public-uplift will be considered to be in a class of its own.

Community Sadhana

This pilgrimage is helping to realize community sadhana as explained by Vinobaji. Now-a-days Vinobaji is emphasizing that our efforts must be community efforts and not individual efforts. This pilgrimage is an effort towards community sadhana. It is possible only by elimination of the ego.

Mutual Understanding and Mutual response

Vinobaji says that Brahmacharinis should feel attracted to one another just as people are in family life. The life of Brahmacharya should be as full of affection as the family life. This will be a higher type of affection, a life more filled with love. There is no specific reason behind the affection for good and virtuous friends. Vinobaji expects these sisters to be attracted to one another with a special kind of love. Such mutual affection is required in community sadhana.

Encircling India on Feet

This pilgrimage continues with such a grand and broad-based ideal. The pilgrimage started from Kasturbagram, Indore, on 25th. October 1967. Till February 1975 these pilgrims have travelled through twelve States of India, namely, Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Hariyana, Himachal Pradesh, Punjab, Jammu-Kashmir, Rajasthan, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu and Pondicherry. After visiting the regions of Lord Krishna, Nanak, Lalla, Mira, Gandhi, Jnanoba, Tukaram and others, the pilgrims entered Andhra Pradesh on 5th. March 1973. After covering Central, North and West of India, now the pilgrimage continues to the South of the Vindhyas. Kerala and Karnataka also are being covered and after completing the pilgrimage in South India, the Eastern States of the country, including Orissa, Bihar, Bengal and Assam have to be covered. Thus the entire country will be traversed on foot.

These pilgrims have visited Srilanka also. This means that they have visited two countries.

Happy Vision of the Heart of Man

The pilgrimage goes on unabated. अनिकेतः स्थिरमति—
‘Let wisdom be steadfast while the feet move on.’ Every day they must walk. Every day a new village and a new halt. Not only five or ten, fifty or a hundred, but thousands of miles have to be covered. The pilgrimage has already covered more than twelve thousand miles. Many more thousands of miles have yet to be covered. The pilgrimage has to continue with a happy vision of

the heart of India and of man. They have a happy vision of the emotional integration latent in diversity. There are different States, different languages, different diet and different customs. Yet everywhere the heart of man appears to be alike. Everywhere the same earth, the same sky, the same people, the same human heart, the same affection, the same good wishes, the same faith and the same devotion. Nobody seems a stranger. How could this lengthy pilgrimage continue without this realization? Although our bodies are separate, we are yet one. We are not mere body, we are spirit—not body, but spirit, this we must practise. This is why Vinobaji has said that ultimately all other aims behind this pilgrimage are secondary. The main aim is only one, to realize that God pervades the whole universe and wherever we go we must have a vision of God in all. The pilgrimage must be continued as a prayer to God.

A Mobile Brahma Vidya Mandir

In this sense this programme is veritably a mobile Brahma Vidya Mandir. The fixed Brahma Vidya Mandir for women, inspired by Vinobaji is at Pavnar. In the form of this pilgrimage, a mobile Brahma Vidya Mandir is wandering from village to village. Vinobaji has a special sentiment for women. He frequently says of his family that all three brothers have remained brahma-charis, but his sister had to marry. Why should it be so? For the emancipation of the self, sisters have as much spiritual right to self-realization as brothers. This pilgrimage is a symbol of this sentiment of Vinobaji. Wandering from village to village, it spreads the message

of revolt against the discrimination between man and woman.

Only with the Power of the Spirit

People are surprized to see that only women are out on such a pilgrimage. Firstly a pilgrimage on foot, and that for twelve years, and that too by four women. It would be all right for men, but how can women walk thus for twelve years? We have to revolt against this curiosity, this astonishment. If it is possible for men, then why not for women? Is the soul of a woman different from that of a man? Is one a male soul and the other a female soul? As a matter of fact there may be physical differences, but there is no difference in the soul. The spirit knows no difference. Today we cannot recognize the soul. Therefore the external form of our bodies has become our main concern. This is why we are so obsessed with physical differences. If we could rise above this difference and regard ourselves as a manifestation of the divine soul, we could be aware of and experience the strength inherent in the soul. Power resides neither in the body of man nor of woman, it resides in the spirit. The object of this pilgrimage is to awaken the power of the spirit which is at present dormant. Moreover, it continues on the basis of the power of the spirit. Therefore there is no fatigue, no hesitation, nor any hindrance. The intoxicated Mira sang :

‘तेरा कोई नहीं रोकनहार
मगन होइ मीरा चली !’

“There is none to stop you ! Happily, Mira walks on, walks on !”

Only for Twelve years

What intense joy, diligence and self-confidence ! They have to continue walking with this single mindedness and self-confidence. Charaiveti ! Charaiveti !—Walk ! Walk thou ! Walk on ! This is the command of the Vedas. This is the tradition of India. How many realized men and saints have wandered continuously for the welfare of the people : वसंतवत् लोकहितं चरन्ति, कृतं संपद्यते चरन्—

‘One who walks lives in the Krita Yuga, the Satya Yuga and his fortune also moves on.’ Lord Buddha thought that we should wander for the welfare of the many and the true pleasure of the many. The ‘Aniket’ mantra in the Bhagavad Gita also teaches this, and Vinobaji, the greatest saint of our times, has also translated this mantra of the Vedas into action. He has prescribed this mantra for all workers and has given this special programme of a twelve-year pilgrimage for these four women. For twelve years, Walk ! Walk thou ! Walk on !

This pilgrimage began with this mantra, it is continuing with it, and it will continue with it. They have to walk for the awakening of women's power. They have to walk to spread Brahmavidya. They have to walk for the emotional integration of India. They have to walk for the unity and peace of the world. They have to walk to spread the message of a non-violent revolution. They have to walk to educate the people with motherly love. They have to walk for the vision of God everywhere. For twelve years—charaiveti ! Charaiveti ! Walk ! Walk thou ! Walk on !! Walk ! Walk thou ! Walk on !! Walk ! Walk thou ! Walk on !!

APPENDIX-I

Information in a Nutshell

(Till February 6th, 1975)

1. Pilgrimage began from Kasturbagram, Indore on 25th October, 1967.
2. Pilgrimage continued till 25th January, 1968. Review of the experiences at Rajgriha with Vinobaji.
3. Pilgrimage resumed in District Sarguja, Madhya Pradesh on 26th. February, 1968.
4. Journey from Punjab to Bihar in October 1969 to attend the Rajgriha Sarvodaya Conference.
5. Pilgrimage began again in District Varanasi of Uttar Pradesh on 2nd November, 1969.
6. Reached Pavnar Ashram, on 1st December, 1972 and stayed ten weeks with Vinobaji.
7. Started from Pavnar on 12th. February, 1973.
8. To Shrilanka on 9th. August, 74. Return to India on 15th November, 1974. Villages travelled 96, Meetings 85, Distance covered 657 Miles, Districts 8.
9. Pilgrimage started from Ramnath District, Tamilnadu on 17th. November, 1974.
10. Pilgrimage in 115 Districts, Statewise :
Madhya Pradesh-6; Uttar Pradesh-9; Hariyana-7;

Himachal Pradesh-3; Punjab-11; Jammu & Kashmir-7; Rajasthan-11; Gujarat-15; Maharashtra-11; Andhra Pradesh-14; Tamilnadu-12; Pondicherry-1.

11. Entered Kerala on February 7th., 1975.
12. Number of Halts—2190. Number of Meetings and groups discussions etc. 5738.
13. Total distance covered about 16000 Miles.
14. Sarvodaya Literature sold during the Pilgrimage—about Rs. 70000/-
15. Number of subscribers enrolled for Sarvodaya periodicals—about 3200. ●

APPENDIX-II

GLOSSARY

- ABHISHEK** : The act of pouring water over the head of an idol in the course of worship.
- ACHARYA KUL** : (The ancient tradition of enlightened teachers) The race of teachers—an organization of teachers and professors suggested by Vinobaji to act as impartial advisers on public matters and social values.
- ADISHANKARA** : see Shankara.
- ADIVASI** : The aboriginal inhabitants of India. Now mostly confined to the forest areas.
- AHILYA BAI** : A Queen of Indore who was much concerned for the welfare of her subjects. She also built many temples and constructed many roads in distant parts of India.
- AMALA PRABHA-**
DAS : A prominent woman social worker of Assam.
- ANGULIMAL** : A brigand who decorated himself with a garland of the thumbs of his murdered victims. He was converted to new life by Lord Buddha.

- ANIKET** : One without a home, as contrasted to Vishwaniket (whose home is the world) i.e. these are one and the same.
- ARATI** : worship or welcome by moving a lighted lamp in front of the object of worship or welcome.
- ASHRAMITE** : One who lives in an Ashram and leads a life of austerity.
- AVAJO** : A farewell greeting meaning 'Come again'.
- BAHIN** : Sister.
- BALYA** : A brigand who was converted by Naradmuni and later became the sage Valmiki.
- BHAGAT SINGH** : A revolutionary worker of the Punjab who was imprisoned in several assassination of British Officers who had perpetrated atrocities. He also threw a bomb in the Assembly. Sentenced to deportation for life on some counts but finally sentenced to death by a special tribunal and executed on 23rd March, 1931.
- BHAGAVAD GITA** : A short but comprehensive Hindu Scripture which has attained the status of Hindu Bible.
- BHARAT** : India.
- BHARATYATRA** : A pilgrimage of whole India.
- BHASMASUR** : The demon of fire. His touch burnt

- everything to ashes. Ultimately he also destroyed himself by placing his hand on his own head.
- BHIKSHUNI** : Buddhist and Jain nun who live on alms.
- BHOODAN** : The act of giving a land-gift, a movement instituted by Vinobaji to appeal to landowners to part with a portion of their land as a voluntary gift to the landless.
- BRAHMA** : The ultimate Reality.
- BRAHMACHARINI** : A woman who observes brahmacharya.
- BRAHMACHARYA** : Discipline that goes with learning and which implies a way of life moving towards self-enlightenment. Customarily however it is translated as self-control and continence.
- BRAHMA VIDYA** : Spirituality. The Knowledge of the Supreme—the ultimate Reality.
- BRAHMA VIDYA-**
MANDIR : An ashram founded by Vinobaji for women who aspire for brahmavidya.
- BRAHMIN** : The highest Hindu caste, traditionally teachers or priests.
- BURQAH** : The robe or veil (usually dark coloured) worn by Muslim women, which covers them from head to foot.
- CHARAIVETI** : Walk ! Walk thou ! Walk on !
- CHARANACHAKRA** : See Dharmachakra.
- Dak BUNGALOW** : Resthouse or a bungalow to accommodate passing travellers.

- DARSHAN** : The act of coming face to face with ultimate Reality or a vision of Reality.
- DHARMACHAKRA** : The wheel of right action or a way of life governed by the universal law of life, propounded by Buddha.
- DHRITI** : Perseverance.
- DWAPAR YUGA** : One of the four eras according to Hindu religion : 1. Satya Yuga, the era of full truth. 2. Treta Yuga, the era in which there are three parts of truth and one part of evil. 3. Dwapar Yuga, the era in which there are two parts of truth and two parts of evil. 4. Kali Yuga (the present era) in which there is one part of truth and three parts of evil.
- DWARIKA** : A place of pilgrimage on the west coast of Gujarat where Shri Krishna is said to have spent the later part of His life.
- GANGAJAL** : Water of the Ganges.
- GITA PRAVACHAN** : Talks on the Bhagavad Gita delivered by Vinobaji in Dhulia Jail.
- GITAYI** : A Marathi version of the Gita in verse, composed by Vinobaji.
- GOPI** : A dairy maid. The childhood companions of Shri Krishna. A shepherdess.
- GRAMDAN and**
GRAMSWARAJYA : The voluntary establishment of self-sufficient and self-governed village

republics under these conditions :—

1. The land to be owned by the village council, but individually cultivated. 2. One-twentieth of the agricultural produce and one day's earnings per month of cash earnings to be donated to the village council. 3. One-twentieth of the land to be distributed amongst the landless. 4. Village council consisting of one member from each family to elect a "service committee" by consensus—all decisions by consensus—to plan for village self sufficiency and social responsibility.

GURU

: A spiritual guide, usually accepted as being infallible. Colloquially, a teacher.

GURUDEO

: A respectful term for a teacher. Term commonly used for Ravindranath Tagore.

GURUDWARA

: Place of worship of the Sikhs.

GURU GRANTH-

SAHEB : A scripture of the Sikhs.

HALDI KUNKUM

: Welcome by anointing the forehead with turmeric powder which is considered auspicious.

HOLI

: A spring festival in which people play by throwing coloured powder or coloured water.

- INQUILAB** : Revolution;—*xindabad* : long live the revolution.
- ISSUFGOL** : a herbal laxative.
- JAI JAGAT** : Long live the world, a slogan of greeting evolved by Vinobaji.
- JAI JAWAN,**
JAI KISAN : 'Long live soldier, Long live the peasant'—a slogan evolved by Shri Lal Bahadur Shastri, a former Prime Minister of India.
- JAIN** : A follower of the Jain religion, founded by Mahavir Swami.
- JAI SHRI**
KRISHNA : long live Lord Krishna.
- JALEBI** : an Indian sweetmeat.
- JNANADEVA**
CHINTANIKA : A selection from the writings of Jnanadeva by Vinobaji.
- JNANESHWARI** : Commentary on the Geeta by Jnanadeva.
- JNANOBA** : (Jnanadeva) a great saint of Maharashtra.
- KALI YUGA** : See Dwapar Yuga.
- KARUNA** : See Satya.
- KASTURBA TRUST** : The institution founded in memory of Gandiji's wife, for service of village-women by women.
- KHADI** : Hand-spun and hand-woven cloth. The non-violent weapon of the freedom movement in India.
- KHUDAI KHIDM-**
ATGAR : A servant of God (i.e. of the people).

KIRTI	: Fame.
KRISHNA	: See Shri Krishna.
KSHMA	: Forgiveness.
LAKH	: One hundred thousand.
LEZIM	: A particular kind of musical exercise.
LOKANITI	: The ethical way of life or politics governed by people's consensus, as the ultimate sanction of all socio-political policies.
LOKA-TANTRA	: The system of government by Lokaniti.
LOKA-YATRA	: Pilgrimage towards the people.
MADHAVADEO	: a great saint and teacher of Assam.
MAHATMA	: A great soul.
MAHAVIR	: great hero—see also Vir (hero).
MAHILA	: Woman—Literally great.
MANTRA	: Incantation.
MEDHA	: Talent.
MIRA BAI	: A woman saint of Rajasthan, a devotee of Shri Krishna.
MUNI	: Sage.
NAGAR SWARAJYA	: Organization of municipalities on lines similar to those of Gram Swarajya.
NAI TALIM	: New education. A system of self-supporting education evolved by Mahatma Gandhi, based on a productive basic craft. Intellectual education to be correlated to the basic craft and the social and physical environment.

NAMA GHOSHA	: A religious book of Assam.
NARAYANA	: One of the forms of God.
NIVRATTI	: Renunciation.
PADAYATRA	: A pilgrimage on foot.
PANCHAYAT	: The ancient system of decision by a council of five.
PANDAS	: Guides at pilgrim centres, today usually considered to be unscrupulous and greedy.
PAPAD	: A cake made of pulse etc.
PASHAM	: The soft underwool of lambs.
PRAMAD	: Error.
PRAVRATTI	: Action.
PREM	: Love, See Satya.
PURDAH	: Literally curtain or the custom of forbidding women to appear in public or meet men. Such women have to keep their faces veiled.
RAJASIK	: Inspired by desire.
RAMA	: The hero of the Ramayana. Worshipped by Hindus as the incarnation of Vishnu.
RAMACHARIT-	
MANAS	: The story of Rama as written in Hindi by Tulsi Das, a great Saint of the North.
RASHTRA MATA	: The mother of the Nation.
RAVANA	: A character in the Ramayana symbolizing evil, ultimately vanquished by Rama.
RISHI	: Sage.

- SADHANA** : Efforts or endeavours for spiritual growth under some discipline.
- SADHVINI** : A woman devotee or nun.
- SAL MUBARAK** : A happy New year.
- SAMADHI** : Place where the spirit of a Saint or Yogi left the body to become one with God, over which a shrine is built.
- SAMUHIK SAD-**
HANA : Community efforts for mutuality in spiritual growth.
- SAMYA YOGA** : The Yoga (or union) of equality, as opposed to Samyavad (communism) the "ism" of equality.
- SARVODAYA** : The uplift of all. The name given to Gandhiji's economic, social and political philosophy.
- SARVODAYA**
PATRA : A vessel for donation of hand-ful grain daily for Sarvodaya cause by the smallest member of family.
- SATVIK** : Pure and free from attachment.
- SATYA** : Truth; Prem (Love); Karuna (compassion)—mottos evolved during Vinobaji's pilgrimage.
- SATYAGRAHA** : Adherence to truth.
- SATYA YUGA** : See Dwapar Yuga.
- SHANKARA** : (The first) Expounder of the philosophy of Vedant. Born in Kerala and founded monasteries in the four corners of India.
- SHANKARDEO** : a great saint and learned man of

- Assam.
- SHANTI SAINIK** : A soldier of peace.
- SHANTI SENA** : Peace Brigade suggested by Gandhiji for the non-violent settlement of internal, and subsequently international disputes.
- SHANTI SENA VIDYALAYA** : Training school for Shanti Sainiks.
- SHIVA** : The third of the trinity of Hindu gods—the Creator, the Sustainer and the Destroyer.
- SHRI** : A title of address.
- SHRI KRISHNA** : The incarnation of God. According to the Hindu Scripture the destroyer of Kans, the symbol of evil, the teacher of the Gita.
- SHRIPHAL** : Dried coconut used in welcome ceremony.
- SMRITI** : Memory.
- STRI-SHAKTI** : Women's power.
- TAPA** : Austerity.
- TARUN (TARN-EVALA)** : A Youth, one who helps in overcoming difficulties.
- TILAK** : The application of a red mark on the forehead on auspicious occasions.
- TIRRUKKURAL** : a religious book of South India.
- TOOFAN** : Swift storm. Name given by Vinobaji to his final concentrated movement for gramdan.
- TRETA YUGA** : See Dwapar Yuga.

UTTAR BUNYADI : Post-basic stage of Nai Talim.

VALMIKI : See Balya.

VANI : Speech.

VEDAS : The most ancient books of the world, sacred to the Hindus.

VIBHUTI YOGA : Yoga of Divine Glory.

VISHNU SAHASTRA-

NAMA : The thousand names of God, enumerated in the Mahabharata.

VISHWA-

MANUSHYA : The universal man.

VIR : See Mahavir

VISWANIKET : See 'aniket'.

VRAJ : The land of Shri Krishna's childhood play.

-YAGNYA : A form of sacrificial worship.

YATRA : Pilgrimage or journey.

YUGA : Era

YUGA PURUSHA : The man of the era.

ZILA DAN : A district (Zila) in which at least 80% of the villages have signed the gramdan pledge.

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